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- Your correct information determines growth for many years to come





उत्तराखण्ड शासन



देवभूमि रजत उत्सव
RAJAT UTSAV (2025-2026)

जन-जन की सरकार

4 साल बेमिसाल

उत्तरोत्तर विकास पथ पर अग्रसर

उत्तराखण्ड





“ प्रधानमंत्री श्री नरेन्द्र मोदी जी के दूरदर्शी मार्गदर्शन में उत्तराखण्ड सर्वांगीण विकास की नई मिसाल बन रहा है। स्थानीय उत्पाद, बेहतर कनेक्टिविटी, उद्योग एवं निवेश तथा हर मौसम पर्यटन सहित देवभूमि अपनी अलौकिक विरासत को संजोते हुए विकास के नए आयाम छू रही है। ”

पुष्कर सिंह धामी, मुख्यमंत्री, उत्तराखण्ड



“ 21वीं सदी के विकसित भारत के निर्माण के दो प्रमुख स्तंभ हैं। पहला, अपनी विरासत पर गर्व और दूसरा, विकास के लिए हर संभव प्रयास। आज उत्तराखण्ड इन दोनों ही स्तंभों को लगातार मजबूत कर रहा है। ये दशक उत्तराखण्ड का दशक है। ”

नरेन्द्र मोदी, प्रधानमंत्री



विकसित भारत सशक्त उत्तराखण्ड

विरासत भी, विकास भी



इंफ्रास्ट्रक्चर एवं कनेक्टिविटी

- केदारनाथ-हेमकुंड साहिब रोपवे परियोजना
- दिल्ली-देहरादून एलिवेटेड रोड निर्माण
- ऋषिकेश-कण्ठप्रयाग रेल लाइन प्रगति पर
- टनकपुर-बागेश्वर रेल सर्वे स्वीकृत
- सौंग व जमरानी बांध परियोजना
- पर्वतीय जिलों में हेली सेवा विस्तार



अर्थव्यवस्था, निवेश एवं उद्योग

- ₹3.56 लाख करोड़ निवेश समझौते
- ₹1 लाख करोड़+ ग्राउंडिंग
- अर्थव्यवस्था 26 गुना वृद्धि
- ₹1.11 लाख करोड़+ वार्षिक बजट
- खुरपिया में स्मार्ट इंडस्ट्रियल टाउनशिप
- हाउस ऑफ हिमालयाज ब्रॉड



हरित ऊर्जा एवं ग्रामीण विकास

- 1 गीगावाट+ सौर ऊर्जा क्षमता
- 42,000+ सोलर रूफटॉप
- वाइब्रेंट विलेज प्रोग्राम (सीमांत गांव विकास)
- महक क्रांति व मिलेट्स मिशन



संस्कृति एवं विरासत का संरक्षण

- केदारनाथ-बदरीनाथ मास्टर प्लान
- मानसखण्ड मंदिर माला मिशन
- शीतकालीन यात्रा का शुभारंभ
- संस्कृत ग्राम पहल
- गीता अध्ययन पाठ्यक्रम में शामिल
- दून विश्वविद्यालय में हिंदू अध्ययन केंद्र
- स्पिरितुअल इकोनॉमिक ज़ोन (गढ़वाल-कुमाऊं)



सुशासन

- 'जन-जन की सरकार, जन-जन के द्वार' अभियान
- 30,000+ युवाओं को सरकारी नौकरी
- 950+ सेवाएं ऑनलाइन (अपुणि सरकार पोर्टल)
- 12,000 एकड़ अतिक्रमण मुक्त
- पेंशन योजनाओं में वृद्धि एवं मासिक भुगतान



बड़े निर्णय

- समान नागरिक संहिता
- सशक्त भू-कानून
- सख्त धर्मांतरण विरोधी कानून
- नकल विरोधी कानून
- अग्निवीरों को 10% क्षेतिज आरक्षण



संकल्प

शिखर तक



नेशनल लेवल रैंकिंग व प्रोत्साहन

- निर्यात तैयारी सूचकांक में प्रथम (छोटे राज्य)
- एसडीजी इंडेक्स में शीर्ष स्थान
- स्टार्टअप रैंकिंग में 'लीडर'
- खनन सुधारों में देश में दूसरा स्थान
- शहरी सुधारों हेतु ₹264.5 करोड़ प्रोत्साहन



30 से अधिक नीतियां

- औद्योगिक नीति, पर्यटन एवं योग नीति
- नई फिल्म नीति (50% तक सब्सिडी)
- मिलेट्स नीति, कीवी नीति (70% अनुदान)
- ड्रैगन फ्रूट प्रोत्साहन योजना
- महक क्रांति 2026-36
- महिला स्वरोजगार एवं लक्ष्यपति दीदी योजना आदि

नीतिगत सुधार



प्रधानमंत्री जी के नौ आग्रह

स्थानीय लोगों से: बोली-भाषा का संरक्षण, एक पेड़ मां के नाम, स्वच्छ जल, गांव से जुड़ाव, तिबारी वाले घरों को संवारें

पर्यटकों से: प्लास्टिक के इस्तेमाल से बचें, वोकल फॉर लोकल, यातायात के नियम अपनाएं, तीर्थों की मर्यादा का पालन करें।

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Former JD(U) leader
K.C. Tyagi joins RLD

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NATION-WIDE BLACKOUT
Cuba reels
under
power grid
collapse

WORLD » PAGE 14



KEY RESOURCE
Govt. to auction 19
critical mineral blocks

NEWS » PAGE 10

Will completely close Hormuz Strait: Iran after Trump's threat

U.S. President had threatened to 'obliterate' Iran's power plants if Tehran did not fully reopen the Strait within 48 hours; hitting back, Iran's Parliament Speaker says critical infrastructure in West Asia could be 'irreversibly destroyed' if attacked

Reuters
Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON/TEHRAN

The Iranian military on Sunday threatened to completely shut down the strategic Strait of Hormuz and attack U.S. infrastructure, including energy facilities in the Gulf, if U.S. President Donald Trump acts on threats to target the country's power plants.

Mr. Trump on Saturday threatened to "obliterate" Iran's power plants if Tehran did not fully reopen the Strait of Hormuz within 48 hours, suggesting a significant escalation barely a day after he talked about "winding down" the war, now in its fourth week.

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said that the U.S. may need to "esca-



Assessing damage: People inspecting the site of an Iranian missile strike in Dimona, Israel on Sunday. AFP

late" its attacks against Iran to be able to wind down the war. Asked if Mr. Trump was winding down or escalating the war, he said: "They're not mutually exclusive. Sometimes you have to escalate to de-escalate."

The strait has been ef-

fectively closed since the start of the war, sparked by U.S.-Israeli bombardment of Iran. The conflict has since spread across West Asia, with Iran responding with attacks on Israel and U.S. interests in the region.

"If the U.S.'s threats regarding Iran's power plants

PM chairs meet to review impact of conflict on India

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

As tensions continue to mount in West Asia, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday chaired a meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) to review the

situation and suggest mitigating measures.

A government statement said that the conflict's impact over the short, long and medium term were assessed.

FULL REPORT ON
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are carried out... the Strait of Hormuz will be completely closed, and it will not be reopened until our destroyed power plants are rebuilt," military's operational command Khatam Al-Anbiya said.

Iran's Parliament Speaker Mohammad Baqer Gha-

libaf wrote on X that critical infrastructure in West Asia could be "irreversibly destroyed" should Iranian power plants be attacked.

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IN BRIEF



Budget Session of Delhi Assembly to begin today

NEW DELHI

The Budget Session of the Delhi Assembly is expected to begin on a stormy note on Monday, with Leader of the Opposition Atishi threatening a boycott over the suspension of four AAP MLAs. » Page 2

Oppn. holds stir in Punjab over official's death

CHANDIGARH

Opposition parties in Punjab on Sunday protested against the ruling AAP, seeking the arrest of its leader Laljit Singh Bhullar, who is allegedly linked to an official's death. » Page 4

EDUCATION PLUS » PAGE 17

BJP will fail to make any electoral gains in Kerala: Pinarayi

S. Anandan
KANNUR

Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan says recent defections by several Left Democratic Front leaders to the Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to contest the State Assembly election demonstrate betrayal and an erosion of values on their part. They will be powerless to ruffle the Left's electoral fortunes, he adds.

In an interview on Saturday with *The Hindu*, the Chief Minister spoke about why he considered the Congress a B-team of the BJP and why the BJP would fail to make any electoral gains in the State this time as well.

Mr. Vijayan said setbacks to the Left Front in some places in the local body elections could not be construed as a prevalent anti-incumbency sen-

timent against the State government.

The Left, he said, has maintained a good relationship with all communities, ruling out consolidation of community votes against the ruling front.

He said the government had strived to bring Kerala in step with modern times, and the people would recognise the effort.

The Kerala Chief Minister called the BJP's "develop Kerala" slogan duplicitous, citing the Centre's "callous" attitude towards the State in the face of adversities.

INTERVIEW
ON
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Shanmugam told presspersons here that party leaders had met DMK president and Chief Minister M.K.

Assam police camp attacked by ULFA(1); 4 commandos hurt

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Four Assam police commandos were injured in an extremist attack in Tinsukia district of eastern Assam on Sunday morning.

District officials said the assailants fired indiscriminately and lobbed several grenades at the commando camp at Jagun, close to the boundary with Arunachal Pradesh.

The commandos retaliated and the gunfight continued for about 30 minutes before the attackers slipped away.

The United Liberation Front of Assam (Independent) claimed responsibility for the attack.

Three of those wounded were rushed to the hospital with grievous injuries. "We have launched an operation in coordination with other forces to find the attackers," an official said.

The Chief Minister condemned the attack and promised action

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma condemned the attack. "Those who have done this will be caught," Mr. Sarma said.

The ULFA(I) said that Operation Bujoni was carried out in retaliation for the police's repeated action against the banned outfit, and alleged drone attacks by the Army on its camps last year.

It asked the State police force to "refrain from subversive activities" against the outfit, warning of retaliatory action.

Jagun is less than 50 km from the nearest point of Arunachal Pradesh's border with Myanmar, where the ULFA(I) has its camps. (With inputs from PTI)

Tamil Nadu election: CPI(M) seeks time to discuss DMK's offer of five Assembly seats

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

On a day when Tamizhaga Vazhvirimai Katchi leader T. Velmurugan exited the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam-led alliance in Tamil Nadu, the Communist Party of India (Marxist) left a small window of opportunity open on Sunday afternoon, saying it would revisit the DMK's offer of only five seats for the April 23 Assembly election.

CPI(M) State secretary P.



Shanmugam told presspersons here that party leaders had met DMK president and Chief Minister M.K.

Stalin to explain its State Committee's decision to contest six seats.

"But the Chief Minister has asked us to accept five seats, as new parties have joined the alliance. We will again discuss the Chief Minister's suggestion in our State Secretariat meeting and convey our decision to him," Mr. Shanmugam said after meeting Mr. Stalin.

The CPI(M) Secretariat meeting was likely to be held on Sunday evening or Monday. He said the State

Committee and Secretariat meetings held on Saturday had decided there was no need to increase the stakes beyond six seats. The party's general secretary, M.A. Baby, attended the meeting. Mr. Shanmugam said the CM had explained to the CPI(M) seat-sharing committee the difficulties in parting with more seats.

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INBRIEF



Massive landslide hits Mandi after rain; 9 houses evacuated

Directions were issued to evacuate nine houses at Ropdu village in Himachal Pradesh's Mandi district on Sunday following a massive landslide. A landslide occurred in Kotli subdivision following intermittent rains over the past three days. A cow shed was completely damaged, while large boulders and debris remain precariously perched on the hillside, continuing to pose a grave and immediate threat to the village below. Officials and the former village head rushed to the scene and directed the evacuation of the nine houses that had been endangered. A video of the landslide went viral on social media. PTI

15 deer killed by stray dogs at rescue centre in Chhattisgarh

As many as 15 deer were killed after a pack of stray dogs attacked them inside an enclosure at an animal rescue centre in Chhattisgarh's Surguja district, officials said on Sunday. The Forest Department has suspended four officials, including a deputy ranger and three forest guards, for alleged negligence in connection with the incident that occurred at Sanjay Van Vatika in Ambikapur on the intervening night of Friday and Saturday. Fourteen deer died on Saturday while one critically injured animal succumbed to its injuries on Sunday, Surguja Divisional Forest Officer Abhishek Jogawat said. PTI

Oppn. stages stir over govt. official's death in Punjab, seeks ex-Minister's arrest

Cong., BJP, Akali Dal leaders demand CBI probe; police use water cannons to disperse protesters trying to lay siege to CM's house; won't perform last rites until Bhullar is held, say deceased's kin

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

Opposition parties in Punjab on Sunday staged a protest against the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) demanding the arrest of its leader Laljit Singh Bhullar, who had stepped down as Minister a day earlier after his name surfaced in connection with the death of a State warehousing corporation official.

Gagandeep Singh Randhawa, district manager of the Punjab State Warehousing Corporation in Amritsar, allegedly died by suicide early on Saturday.

In a purported video linked to the incident, Randhawa is heard accusing Mr. Bhullar of pressuring him to award a tender to the Minister's aide.

Leaders of Opposition parties, including the Congress, Bharatiya Janata Party, and the Shiromani Akali Dal, took out a joint protest demanding a CBI probe into the case. Police used wa-



Police personnel trying to stall the progress of protesters attempting to head towards the CM's residence, in Chandigarh on Sunday. PTI

ter cannons to disperse the protesters as they tried to lay siege to Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's house.

"The facts clearly establish cognisable offences. The law must take its course without delay or dilution," Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly Partap Singh Bajwa said.

He demanded that provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act be invoked against Mr. Bhullar for "misusing his position to coerce a public servant in-

to committing illegal acts".

Together for justice

The AAP leader's "hooliganism, corruption, and threats pushed a capable officer to death, and all Opposition parties had to unite and raise their voice for justice", Bikram Singh Majithia of the Akali Dal said.

State BJP chief Sunil Jakhar said after strong public opposition the AAP government was forced to register a case against the Minister, but no arrest has

been made yet. "There is no hope of justice from this government," he said.

Meanwhile, the family of the deceased said they will not perform the last rites or permit a post-mortem examination until the accused is arrested. "We want justice," Upinder Kaur, Randhawa's wife, told reporters in Amritsar.

She alleged that her husband was "forced to admit he had accepted bribe of ₹10 lakh" when he was summoned to the Minister's residence in Patti. "This happened on March 13. Unable to bear the torment, my husband took his own life," she alleged.

Late on Saturday night, police booked Mr. Bhullar, his father Sukhdev Singh Bhullar, and personal assistant Dilbag Singh under Sections 108 (abetment of suicide), 351(3) (criminal intimidation) and 3(5) (common intention) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help.)

More schemes for women if SP comes to power: Akhilesh

Press Trust of India
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) chief Akhilesh Yadav said on Sunday that if his party comes to power in the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly poll, it will introduce more initiatives focused on the education of daughters and the welfare of mothers and sisters.

Speaking at a programme held at the Samajwadi Party office in Lucknow, he said, "To truly understand a society or a nation, one must examine the status of its women, and an assessment reveals the overall condition of the entire society. In India, which is home to diverse castes and religions, it becomes evident that the situation of our women and sisters is, in fact, dire."

The SP chief assured that the party will implement better schemes concerning women's safety, health, honour, and prosperity in the future.

PDA to empower women

"I assure you that genuine progress is unattainable without the involvement of 'aadhi aabaadi (half the population)' - that is, women. While the strength of



Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav addressing a press conference at the party office in Lucknow on Sunday. ANI

the People's Democratic Alliance (PDA) lies in the Other Backward Classes, Dalits, Minorities, and our Muslim brothers, we cannot advance society and the nation without the support of this 'half of the population'. By forming a government through the PDA, we will implement schemes aimed at honouring women and leading them toward a prosperous life, thereby promoting their empowerment and upliftment," he said.

Former Uttar Pradesh Chief Secretary Alok Ranjan, who attended the programme, noted that between 2012 and 2017, when Mr. Yadav was the Chief Minister, numerous initiatives were undertaken for the upliftment of women.

Clamour grows in Haryana Cong. to name MLAs whose votes were declared invalid in RS election

The Hindu Bureau
GURUGRAM

Two days after the Haryana Congress issued show-cause notices to five party MLAs for "cross-voting" in the Rajya Sabha poll on March 16, there is growing clamour for action against the four MLAs whose votes were declared invalid.

The demand was raised on Sunday by party leader Nazim Chaudhary, son of Hathin MLA Chaudhary Mohd. Israil, one of the five MLAs accused of "cross-voting". The party had also issued show-cause notices to MLAs Muhammad Ilyas, Renu Bala, Shalley Chaudhary, and Jarnail Singh.

Earlier, wrestler-turned politician and Julana MLA Vinesh Phogat and Badli MLA Kuldeep Vats had also raised similar demands.

Intentional move

"An MLA is imparted proper training to vote in a Rajya Sabha election. These mistakes [casting invalid votes] are intentional. I think action must be initiated against all nine MLAs," Mr. Nazim said, adding that he has severed all ties with his father and uncle, a senior police officer, for their alleged involvement in "cross-voting".

"Even if some big leaders are involved, action should be taken against

them as well. It is happening for the third time," he said, referring to the previous occasions when the Congress's Rajya Sabha candidates in Haryana lost despite the party having the requisite numbers.

Speaking to reporters during a visit to Mr. Vats's residence on Sunday, Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly Bhupinder Singh Hooda said the four Congress votes were "forcibly" declared invalid.

State Congress chief Rao Narender Singh, however, told The Hindu over phone that action would also be initiated against the legislators whose votes were declared invalid if the party

comes across any strong evidence against them.

"Whether the votes were crossed or cancelled, the intention was the same in both cases. Nothing happens without reason in such situations; there should be no ifs or buts. The party should take action with this mindset," Ms. Phogat had said in a post on X on March 18.

With two more Rajya Sabha seats set to fall vacant in the State in 2028, the Congress seems to be treading with caution with regard to taking action against its MLAs. The party is looking to avoid rash decisions that could hurt its prospects in the election.

With deadline looming, Cong., DMK inch closer to seat-sharing deal in Puducherry

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

The Congress and DMK on Sunday broadly agreed to share seats in double digits in the 30-member Puducherry Assembly, which goes to polls on April 9. The Congress candidates may enter the fray in 15 or 16 seats. However, the Congress is yet to officially ratify this arrangement.

The DMK would most likely accommodate the interests of allies such as VCK from its share of seats, sources told The Hindu. The agreement will be formally signed soon to facilitate candidates to file their nominations before



Congress's P. Chidambaram met DMK president M.K. Stalin on Sunday to resolve differences.

the March 23 deadline.

As the two sides were unable to agree on who would lead the alliance in the Union Territory, Congress veteran P. Chidambaram entered the scene yet again and met DMK

president and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Sunday to iron out the differences.

Serious consequences

The sources said Mr. Stalin insisted that the arrangement worked out for Tamil Nadu should be applicable to Puducherry too.

He felt that if anything went wrong in Puducherry, it would have serious consequences for Tamil Nadu. Mr. Stalin was not happy with the manner in which Girish Chodankar, AICC in-charge of the party affairs and head of the seat-sharing committee, handled the talks in Puducherry.

DMK MP S. Jagathrakshakan is in charge of the party in Puducherry.

The AIADMK on Sunday announced its candidates for the Oupalam and Orleanpeth Assembly constituencies. AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami named former legislator A. Anbalagan for Oupalam and A. Gandhi for Orleanpeth.

Meanwhile, Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam president and actor Vijay on Sunday announced the party's candidates for all 30 Assembly segments in Puducherry.

(With inputs from Dennis S. Jesudasan and Sai Charan)

SPOTLIGHT

Rahul Karmakar

Multiple memorials for 11 "language martyrs" remind Silchar, the epicentre of southern Assam's Bengali-dominated Barak Valley, of a massacre on May 19, 1961. Many more dot the valley beyond. The primary memorial, Shahid Minar or Martyrs' Tomb, is at Gandhibag, a popular park at the centre of Silchar. Eleven columns stand in their memory at the town's crematorium, where the last rites of the martyrs were performed.

But the memorial that moves the townspeople the most is a brownish sculpture at the Silchar railway station, where the State police personnel gunned down 11 people, including 16-year-old Kamala Bhattacharya, who had gathered to protest the Assam government's decision to impose Assamese as the only official language.

On Kalimohan Road, about 200 metres from the railway station memorial, stands the expansive house of former Union Minister Santosh Mohan Dev, one of the most influential politicians to emerge from India's Northeast, comprising eight States. The house

of the Congress leader was the power centre of the valley - adjoining Tripura too - for three decades, before it shifted to that of Kabin-dra Purkayastha at Nutanpatty, about 1.5 km from the memorial.

One of the founder-members of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in the Northeast in 1980, Purkayastha did not become as influential as Dev, but initiated the saffron surge in Assam by wresting the Silchar Lok Sabha seat from Dev in 1991 and ensuring 10 Assembly seats, including nine from the Barak Valley, that year.

United by a language

Divided by ideology, the two houses have been united by a demand to rename the Silchar railway station as the Bhasha Shahid (Language Martyrs) railway station. Dev championed this demand, and so did Purkayastha in Parliament. The latter's son, Rajya Sabha member Kanad Purkayastha, refreshed this demand in Delhi in December 2025. Leaders of the Left Front, which briefly called the shots in Barak Valley in the 1970s, were on the same page too.

"Barak Valley was untouched by the violence that swept other parts of Assam after the Babri Mas-

Assam's hurt valley

Barak Valley is where the BJP struck roots in the Northeast. People in this Bengali-dominated part of Assam expected to shed their outlier tag after the party began its electoral victory march in 2014. As the Assembly election approaches, many believe they have been given the short shrift



Silchar town in southern Assam's Bengali-dominated Barak Valley is in election mode. RAHUL KARMAKAR

jid demolition in December 1992. This was because Hindus and Muslims identified themselves as Bengali first. Unfortunately, the bonding over language is loosening due to the BJP brand of polarisation," says Pradip Dutta Roy, an advocate and chief convener of the regional Barak Democratic Front party.

He adds that the BJP no longer produces strong leaders in Barak Valley who can stand up to Dispur's (Assam's seat of power) in the Assamese-dominated Brahmaputra Valley)

"bulldozing decisions".

"After the 1961 incident, the Assam government withdrew its controversial circular to make Bengali the official language in Barak Valley, now comprising Cachar, Hailakandi, and Sribhumi districts. But it tried to push similar circulars in 1972, 1986, and 2013. In 1986, a year after the Assam Agitation, primarily targeting Bengalis, ended, two more protesters were killed in police firing," he says.

Whether it was the Congress (1961, 1972, and

2013), the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP, 1986), or the BJP now, he feels the attitude of the Assam government toward the Barak Valley and its people has not changed. He points to the State government's "reluctance" to give shape to a ₹8-crore Language Martyrs' Memorial Museum announced in 2017.

Faith over tongue

The sentiments associated with the 1961 killing are evident in a flex signboard put up by locals at the Silchar railway station. The sign-

board reads "Bhasha Sahid Railway Station Silchar" in Bengali, Hindi, and English. Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma stirred a debate when he said in 2025 that a no-objection certificate (NOC) sent to the Centre regarding the railway station renaming was pending due to alternative proposals and feedback from other groups.

The Bhasha Shahid Station Shahid Smaran Committee, an organisation seeking justice for the language martyrs, accused him of speaking a "half-truth" and slammed a bid to rename the railway station after a Dimasas tribal freedom fighter "without a direct link to the station".

The organisation's general secretary, Rajib Kar, said the Ministry of Home Affairs acted on a proposal of the Tarun Gogoi-led Congress government in 2016 and issued an NOC in November 2017 and directed the Assam government to process the renaming through a gazette notification. The organisation "fails to understand" why a BJP-led government, which claims the support of Bengali Hindu voters in Assam, has been delaying the notification for nine years.

The neglect of Barak Valley is not only about a railway station or the Ben-

gali language, says Atanu Bhattacharjee, the Silchar Town Congress Committee president. "Bengali Hindus and Muslims continue to be second-class citizens despite comprising more than 40% of Assam's population. In Barak Valley at least, the two communities enjoyed camaraderie until the BJP sowed the seeds of division on religious lines. Still, we hope things will change for the better when the regime changes," he says. The Assam elections are to be held in April.

"Our region receives a step-motherly treatment from the mainstream Assam leadership. We have had to fight for higher education and healthcare institutions, various developmental projects, and even the East-West Corridor project, linking Saurashtra to Silchar is getting delayed," he says. He adds that syndicates controlling businesses and natural resources are being encouraged. "All these are being done behind the Hindu-Muslim narrative to keep the people divided."

He accuses the BJP of resorting to "gutter-level" politics, citing his case as an example. "I was suspended as the Cachar District Sports Association general secretary and locked out of my office just

because I lauded the elevation of Gaurav Gogoi as the Assam Congress president and hoped he would become the Chief Minister."

Ataur Rahman Mazarbhuiya, a former MLA who represented the Badruddin Ajmal-led All India United Democratic Front, agrees with Bhattacharjee.

"There was a time when the tongue, not faith, mattered more in Barak Valley. The bid to keep Muslims in check under the present regime seems to have been a factor behind the delimitation exercise, which has reduced the number of Assembly seats in Barak Valley from 15 to 13," he says.

"Going by population, Barak Valley should have had three more Assembly seats," he adds.

According to the 2011 Census, Muslims are roughly 51% of the population of Barak Valley. The Hindu count is about 47%.

While the BJP seeks another five years to fulfil its promises, the Opposition - fragmented on the surface - believes it is high time others got a chance to do what the saffron brigade could not. "People in the valley are revolting, but quietly. We hope it reflects in the April 9 results," Mazarbhuiya says.

rahul.karmakar@thehindu.co.in



Harvesting anxiety

Assam goes to the polls amidst another political churn

The BJP is seeking a third consecutive term in Assam in Assembly polls on April 9, while the Congress is fighting to make a comeback after 10 years in the wilderness. In 2021, the coalition of BJP, AGP and UPPL won 75 of 126 seats, with the BJP alone winning 60. Communal mobilisation and welfare schemes make the standard BJP toolkit here too, but Assam is a unique theatre of political experimentation for the party and its governments at the State and the Centre. Conflicts over large-scale migration of Bengali-speaking people have long shaped Assam’s politics. Nativist politics developed primarily in opposition to this migration. The BJP’s growth has come by recasting that nativism into a question of Hindu-Muslim conflict, creating a new political dynamic weakening subnational outfits and pressuring the Congress. The Citizenship (Amendment) Act 2019 enacted a communal eligibility clause for people who entered India from Bangladesh. Nativist opposition to citizenship for any immigrant – including Hindus – and other factors stalled the large-scale rollout of the law, but rhetoric over demographic change remains the mainstay of politics. This will be the first Assembly poll after the 2023 delimitation of constituencies, which has displayed patterns of communal gerrymandering, reducing the impact of Muslim voters and enhancing representation for indigenous communities. BJP functionaries, including Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, have been open about the intended impact.

Meanwhile, the BJP continues to recruit leaders from the Congress. The AIUDF, mainly representing Bengali-speaking Muslims in lower Assam and the Barak Valley, contributed to the collapse of the Congress in 2016, now fights for survival, contesting alone after exclusion from the Congress-led Opposition alliance. The Congress has allied with the Rajior Dal, led by activist Akhil Gogoi, and the AJP, a party born from the anti-CAA movement that channels renewed Assamese sub-nationalism among younger voters. Their common ground is the promise of democratic governance, land rights, and inclusive development. The AGP, once the torch-bearer of Assamese regionalism, is a junior NDA partner contesting 26 seats, its independent ideological space largely absorbed by its larger ally. In Bodoland, the BJP has replaced its 2021 partner, the UPPL, with the BPF, an older formation. In 2021, the BJP had managed to subsume most regional sentiment through alliances and the recasting of the migration debate. Big infrastructure projects are presented as milestones, but allegations of crony capitalism and disregard for the environment are serious. Such substantive questions get sidelined as fear rather than hope dominates.

Digital exile

The government could be creating a system of arbitrary censorship

A decade-long trend in digital governance in India crescendoed last week when a slew of social media accounts operated by independent activists and journalists were blocked apparently for criticising the Union government and Prime Minister Narendra Modi over his government’s West Asia policies and the LPG crisis. In seven years, from 2014 to 2021, the number of URLs, posts, and accounts blocked ballooned from 470 to 9,800; since then, there is evidence that entire accounts, especially if they were publishing politically unfavourable comments, were being blocked. There was a wave of censorship during the farmers’ protest in 2020-21; the government restored many accounts after international outcry but this also demonstrated that it was not beyond mass censorship. Similarly, the government used emergency powers under the IT Rules to block links to a BBC documentary in 2023, which also expanded the definition of what constituted a “threat to public order”. But when Twitter (now X) challenged several blocking orders, between 2021 and 2022, in the Karnataka High Court, the High Court dismissed the plea and fined Twitter, further emboldening the state to censor accounts.

In *Shreya Singhal* (2015), the Supreme Court of India upheld Section 69A of the IT Act 2000 precisely because of its procedural safeguards, including requiring reasoned orders and judicial review. In practice, however, the government has been diluting the safeguards through an expansive use of Rule 16 of the 2009 Blocking Rules, which requires blocking proceedings to be confidential. When this stipulation is invoked to withhold blocking orders or their reasons from affected parties, it undermines their ability to challenge the action in court, eroding the very safeguards that justified the constitutionality of Section 69A. The 2009 Rules also require blocking orders to be reviewed by a committee composed under the IT Rules 2009, yet this is an entirely executive body and has never overturned a government blocking order. In effect, the government is openly and systematically bypassing the right to be heard and violating the doctrine of proportionality. Rule 16 is a procedural rule, yet the government is using it to override the constitutional right to free speech while shielding itself from judicial review. A person’s entire account being blocked amounts to a digital exile, removing the person from the public square, which is a hallmark of an authoritarian government rather than of a liberal democracy. The government’s plan to decentralise blocking powers to multiple Ministries could effectively create a regime of arbitrary censorship, where any department can silence a critic without the specialised oversight, however flawed, of the IT Ministry.

‘Double engine’ — cute slogan, a serious federal question

Every election season produces memorable slogans. Most fade once the votes are counted, but some linger and begin to shape how citizens think about governance itself. One such phrase is the “double-engine *sarkar*”. At first hearing, it sounds harmless, even cute: two governments working in tandem to accelerate development. Yet, behind the metaphor lies a serious constitutional question about India’s federal compact.

The idea is simple: if the same party governs both the Union and the State, development will move faster because the two governments will work in harmony. Taken at face value, this is unexceptionable. Of course governments at different levels should coordinate. That is indeed cooperative federalism. The real question is what happens when they do not share the same political ideology. But the “double-engine” slogan carries a deeper implication. It suggests that development flows preferentially to States governed by the same party as the Union government.

‘Aligned States’ benefit

During election campaigns the message is often made quite explicit: elect the party ruling at the Centre so that your State can benefit from faster development. If you do not, you will be starved of funds. This is where the constitutional difficulty begins.

India’s Constitution does not envisage a system where State governments depend on the goodwill, or charity, of the ruling party at the Centre. It creates a federal structure in which the Union and the States are partners within their respective spheres. The Union government represents the Republic as a whole, not merely those States governed by the party in power in New Delhi.

Public money collected through national taxation belongs to the Union of India, not to the ruling party. Taxes are collected in the name of the Republic, from citizens of every State regardless of how they vote. The distribution of these resources cannot depend on which party governs a State. A citizen in Kerala or Tamil Nadu pays the same taxes as a citizen in Uttar Pradesh or Madhya Pradesh. The constitutional promise is that both will receive their fair share in return.

India’s constitutional framers understood this danger. That is why they built institutional safeguards into the system. The most important is the Finance Commission. Under Article 280, the Finance Commission is appointed every five years to recommend how Union revenues should be shared with the States. Its purpose is vital: fiscal transfers must be rule-based, not politically negotiated. The Commission evaluates States on objective criteria – how far their incomes lag



S.Y. Quraishi

is a former Chief Election Commissioner of India

Fairness, not political alignment, must guide India’s federal balance

behind the national average, their population, geographic size, and fiscal capacity – so that politics cannot determine who gets what.

Issues raised by States, federal friction

Recent debates around fiscal federalism show how sensitive this issue remains. Southern States have expressed concern that the use of more recent population data in allocation formulas may penalise them for having successfully controlled population growth. Another issue is the increasing resort of the Union government to cesses and surcharges, which fall outside the divisible pool and are not shared with States. This effectively reduces the quantum of resources available for constitutionally mandated sharing, concentrating more fiscal power in Union hands and weakening the financial autonomy of States. The Sixteenth Finance Commission, which is currently deliberating, will have to grapple seriously with these concerns if it is to restore confidence in the fairness of the fiscal federal arrangement

Governments in Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana have argued that States which acted early to stabilise population should not be penalised in the distribution of national resources. Senior Ministers from these States have at times remarked, in visible frustration, that they feel reduced to “beggars”, pleading for funds that constitutionally belong to them. This is not the language of political theatre. It reflects a genuine structural grievance about the terms on which States participate in the Indian Union.

Federal friction is visible not only in financial matters but also in the legislative process. In recent years, Governors in some States have sat for long periods over Bills passed by elected legislatures, effectively using the constitutional office as an instrument of political sabotage. Tamil Nadu and Kerala have witnessed particularly prolonged delays. The pattern is difficult to ignore: the delays have been in States that are governed by parties opposed to the ruling dispensation at the Centre. A Governor who withholds assent to legislation passed by an elected Assembly is, in effect, a second engine running in reverse.

Such delays have drawn judicial attention. In *State of Punjab vs Principal Secretary to the Governor of Punjab* (2023), the Supreme Court of India made it clear that a Governor cannot use inaction to stall the legislative process. The Court emphasised that the Governor’s office is not meant to function as a parallel political authority over an elected legislature.

More recently, in *State of Tamil Nadu vs Governor of Tamil Nadu* (2025), the Court observed that prolonged inaction by a Governor

in assenting to Bills is constitutionally impermissible. These rulings together signal a firm judicial commitment to protecting the legislative sovereignty of elected State assemblies.

The experience of Delhi over the past decade provides a further illustration. Many initiatives of the elected government became entangled in disputes with the Lieutenant-Governor and the Union government. Courts eventually had to intervene. The lesson is not merely about one city; it is about what happens when the machinery of federal governance is used to punish a political opponent rather than serve the public.

Seen together – fiscal transfers, gubernatorial delays, and the Delhi impasse – these developments form a coherent pattern. The “double-engine” slogan is not merely a campaign metaphor. It is a description of how governance actually functions when political alignment is absent. And that is precisely the constitutional problem. The form of federalism survives; its spirit is quietly hollowed out.

India’s federal system has faced similar tensions before. In earlier decades, Article 356 was frequently misused to dismiss elected State governments. The Court’s landmark judgment in *S.R. Bommai vs Union of India* placed important limits on that practice. The challenge today is subtler: governments may remain in office, yet, governance itself may become hostage to political alignment.

Structural reform needed

What is needed is not merely judicial intervention, but structural reform. The Finance Commission’s recommendations could be made more binding. A fixed statutory timeline, say, three months, could be prescribed for Governors to act on Bills, failing which assent would be deemed granted. Inter-State/governmental councils, already provided for under Article 263, could be revitalised as genuine forums for cooperative federalism rather than ceremonial gatherings. These are not radical proposals; they are logical completions of the constitutional architecture that the framers intended.

Political slogans will continue to animate election campaigns. But a slogan that implicitly threatens citizens with slower development if they choose the “wrong” party at the State level does not merely distort electoral choice; it corrodes the constitutional promise of equal citizenship. Development cannot depend on political alignment. It must rest on rules and institutions that treat every State, and every citizen, with equal fairness. That constitutional balance, not the number of engines pulling the same train, is the only engine India’s federal democracy truly needs.

Trump’s Section 301 weapon, lessons from the past

Within hours of the February 20 ruling of the United States Supreme Court that U.S. President Donald Trump lacked authority to impose his infamous reciprocal tariffs, the U.S. administration invoked Section 122 of the Trade Act of 1974 to impose a 10% temporary surcharge on imports, effective February 24 to July 24, 2026. Section 122 requires the existence of a “balance of payment” (BOP) crisis. This has already been challenged by 24 U.S. States in the United States Court of International Trade, on the ground that, like the preceding tariffs, these too have no legal basis, nor is there any BOP crisis facing the U.S.

Under World Trade Organization (WTO) rules of international trade, import restrictions, not tariffs, are permissible in limited situations involving serious BOP difficulties, which could arise due to actual or any imminent threat of serious decline in a country’s monetary reserves. None of these situations exists for the U.S.

In any event, since the Section 122 tariffs have a limited 150-day shelf life, Mr. Trump promised “other tools” and initiated two sets of “Section 301” proceedings – one alleging “Structural Excess Capacity and Production in Manufacturing Sectors”, and another alleging “Failure to Impose and Effectively Enforce a Prohibition on the Importation of Goods Produced with Forced Labor”. India is listed in both proceedings, along with the European Union (EU), Japan, Singapore, South Korea, China and many others. The factual and economic rationale for both, at best, is specious.

Furthering unilateral action

Section 301 sits under “Title III” of the U.S. Trade Act in the chapter “Enforcement of United States Rights under Trade Agreements and Response to Unfair Trade Practices”. Section 301 authorises the Office of the United States Trade Representative to investigate foreign trade practices and impose unilateral tariffs based on a determination that such practices are



R.V. Anuradha

is a Partner at Clarus Law Associates, New Delhi, specialising in international economic laws

The Section 301 proceedings demand action from India and other developing nations to revive multilateral rules

unjustifiable, discriminatory, or restrict U.S. commerce, or violate trade agreements.

A clear anomaly in Section 301 is that it provides the U.S. the right to unilateral determination of what is governed by rules of international trade. To state the obvious, one cannot be the judge of one’s cause. To address this, soon after the WTO came into being in 1995, the EU initiated a dispute against the U.S. arguing that because Section 301 provides unilateral rights to the U.S. without any assessment of its international obligations, such a provision violated WTO law.

The WTO disputes panel agreed that even the threat of conduct prohibited by the WTO would enable one country to exert undue leverage on others. It compared Section 301 to a “big stick”, that, merely by being carried could be “as effective a means to having one’s way as actually using the stick”.

The panel, however, refrained from holding Section 301 as illegal based on an assurance from the U.S. administration that it would render determinations “in conformity” with its WTO obligations. This deference to the U.S. was predicated on the U.S.’s standing by that assurance. That deference has today come to haunt WTO members.

Now, key decimator

A 2020 report of the U.S. Congressional Research Service (CRS) notes that until the start of the Trump administration (in 2016), the U.S. stood by its word and used Section 301 primarily to build cases and pursue dispute settlement at the WTO. The report acknowledges that the Trump administration changed that and started using Section 301 as a weapon to impose tariffs as punitive measures. Pursuant to Section 301 proceedings against China in 2017, unilateral tariffs up to 25% were imposed. A WTO panel held in 2020 that these tariffs violated the U.S.’s commitments under the WTO. The U.S. did not blink and appealed the panel ruling to the WTO’s

appellate process. The only catch was that there was no WTO Appellate Body by 2020, since the U.S. had, single-handedly, blocked its constitution.

The U.S., as the chief architect of the WTO, including its enforceable dispute settlement mechanism, has been its chief decimator. Had the panel in 1999 ruled that Section 301 required amendment to ensure WTO consistency, the U.S. – then a trustworthy member of the multilateral system that it had helped create – would very likely have amended the section to eliminate any possibility of unilateral tariff imposition. And Mr. Trump’s toolkit would have fallen short of one potent weapon.

The issue of trade agreements

Events over the past year have especially demonstrated the fragility of multilaterally agreed rules, and the significant systemic leverage the U.S. has been able to exercise by unabashed violation of those rules. And yet, we are also seeing some limits to that leverage. Malaysia has officially called its reciprocal trade agreement with the U.S. “null and void” after the U.S. Supreme Court’s decision. Unlike Malaysia, India had not yet signed an agreement with the U.S., and the government has indicated that it hopes for a “mutually beneficial trade agreement”. The pressures of the Section 301 proceedings will, no doubt, play a role in the conclusion of any negotiation.

Indian businesses need to actively participate in both Section 301 proceedings and make clear submissions exposing the absurdity of these so-called investigations. At the broader level, the core challenge for India and other developing countries is the need to revive multilateral rules. There is no substitute for the strength that comes from coalition-building to dilute the U.S.’s raw power advantage. India must step up and play that role.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Trump and war

The prosecution of the conflict with Iran under U.S. President Donald Trump reveals a disconcerting absence of strategic coherence and foresight. The presumption that targeted elimination of leadership would catalyse regime transformation has proven fundamentally flawed, as Iran has exhibited considerable

resilience against the United States-Israel offensive. Compounding this miscalculation is the administration’s oscillatory rhetoric — simultaneously proclaiming operational success while augmenting military deployments — thereby betraying policy inconsistency. Mr. Trump’s disparagement of NATO allies for their reluctance to engage

underscores growing diplomatic estrangement. Concurrently, internal dissent, exemplified by the resignation of Joe Kent, accentuates institutional unease. **N. Sadhasiva Reddy,** Bengaluru

U.S. President Donald Trump appears to recognise no limits. Earlier it was Venezuela; now it is Iran,

and he has openly suggested that Cuba could be next — without clear justification. These actions risk plunging entire nations into crisis and instability. Mr. Trump seems to view global resources, particularly oil, as instruments of power. The international community must respond firmly to check such unilateralism. Otherwise, there may be no

end to these escalating, authoritarian impulses. **N.G.R. Prasad,** Chennai

Military action without a clearly articulated endgame risks prolonged instability, rising human and economic costs, and unintended geopolitical consequences. The concerns raised within the United States Congress reflect not just partisan

debate but the need for strategic clarity, defined objectives, and an exit plan. As tensions with Iran escalate, restraint, transparency, and diplomacy must prevail over open-ended military engagement. **Gopalaswamy J.,** Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Building his own band of loyalists

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of trips under free bus travel scheme since inception

898 crore. Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. K. Stalin on Sunday hailed the success of the ‘Vidiyal Payanam’ free bus travel scheme for women, stating that the initiative has recorded nearly 898 crore trips since its inception. PTI

Number of dog-bite cases in Rajasthan in 2025

900 An RTI application revealed that the State reported more than 460 dog-bite cases in 2024, which rose to over 900 in 2025. Jaipur recorded the highest numbers both years, with cases surging from 307 in 2024 to 633 in 2025. PTI

Percentage increase in Sri Lanka’s fuel prices due to conflict

25 in per cent. Sri Lanka raised fuel prices by 25% on Sunday, as the country prepared for more impact from the war in West Asia. Regular petrol was increased to 398 rupees (\$1.30) per litre, up from 317 rupees, while diesel rose by 79 rupees to 382. AFP

Education systems with a national ban on phones in schools

114 More than half of the countries have banned phones in schools amid mounting concerns about declining attention in classrooms and cyberbullying, according to the UNESCO’s Global Education Monitoring team. PTI

People killed in a strike on a hospital in Sudan

64 At least 64 people were killed, including at least 13 children, in a strike on a hospital in Sudan’s western Darfur region last week, the World Health Organization said on Saturday. AP
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What insurance numbers do not reveal

Insurance penetration and density are widely used indicators, but they show premium collection, not how well households are protected against loss of income; as a result, premium growth is often mistaken for progress, even when financial protection remains limited

ECONOMIC NOTES

T.C. Suseel Kumar
R. Sudhakar

India is often described as an “underinsured” country. This claim is usually backed by two numbers that appear regularly in official speeches, policy papers, and media commentary: life insurance penetration and density. Low values of these indicators are taken as proof that insurance coverage in India is inadequate and that large sections of the population remain unprotected.

The problem is not that these numbers are wrong. The problem is that they are misunderstood – and then used to draw the wrong conclusions during public discourses.

In everyday economic language, penetration refers to how widely a product is used. Mobile phone penetration, for example, tells us what proportion of people or households have access to a phone. Density usually means how much of something exists per person.

In life insurance, however, these terms mean something quite different. Insurance penetration is defined as the total premium collected by insurers as a percentage of gross domestic product (GDP). Insurance density is the average premium paid per person, usually expressed in U.S. dollars. These definitions are internationally accepted and are useful for comparing the size of insurance markets across countries.

But these measures do not tell us what most people assume they do. They do not reveal how many families are insured, whether those families would be financially secure if the main earning member were to die, or whether insurance is serving its most important social purpose – protecting households against sudden loss of income.

What the numbers show

Premium-to-GDP, for instance, is essentially a measure of industry revenue relative to the size of the economy. It can move up or down for many reasons that have little to do with household protection. If the economy grows rapidly



GETTY IMAGES

due to infrastructure spending or increased exports, insurance penetration can fall even if more people are buying insurance.

On the other hand, insurers can push high-premium products and raise penetration figures without meaningfully improving protection.

Regulatory changes can further distort the picture. When product rules or commission structures are modified, premium growth often slows temporarily as insurers recalibrate. Penetration may then appear to decline. This does not mean fewer families are insured – it simply reflects a shift in how insurance is sold and priced. Treating such movements as evidence of poor coverage leads to confused diagnosis and poor decision-making.

Insurance density has similar limitations. It is often used to compare India with richer countries, leading to the conclusion that Indians are underinsured because they spend less on insurance. But such comparisons ignore income levels and cost of living. A family paying a modest premium in India may be making a far greater financial commitment, relative to income, than a family paying a higher premium in a developed economy.

Premium vs protection

More importantly, both penetration and

density confuse how much is paid with how much protection is received. In India, insurance products have long been sold as savings instruments rather than as pure protection. As a result, premiums can be high even when the life cover provided is modest. Premiums rise, but the financial security of dependents does not improve proportionately.

This gap between premiums and protection becomes clearer when claims data are examined. According to the IRDAI Annual Report 2024-25, life insurers settled a little over 10 lakh individual death claims during the year, paying a total of about ₹33,000 crore. This translates to an average payout of roughly ₹3.3 lakh per claim, showing a 97% claim settlement ratio.

While this reflects efficient claim settlement, it also indicates the level of financial support that life insurance typically delivers to bereaved families. For most households, such an amount would replace income for only a short period, if at all. Yet these claim payouts fully count towards insurance penetration and density. The numbers look reassuring, even though the underlying protection is often thin. This is why headline indicators can suggest progress while households remain financially vulnerable.

This confusion matters because it shapes how the problem is framed.

Rethinking adequacy

When India is labelled “underinsured” on the basis of these metrics, the implied conclusion is that people lack awareness or access. In reality, many households – especially in the formal and semi-formal sectors – already own at least one life insurance policy, either individually or through employers. The real issue is not reach, but adequacy. Families may have insurance, but not enough to replace lost income if something goes wrong.

This is not an argument for abandoning penetration and density altogether. These indicators are useful for tracking the growth of the insurance industry and for making broad international comparisons. But they are poorly suited to guiding public policy aimed at household protection. When revenue-based measures are treated as indicators of social security, they obscure more than they reveal.

A more meaningful approach would begin with simpler, more direct questions: how many households actually have some form of life insurance cover – whether individual, employer-provided, or through government schemes? And for those that do, how much life cover do they have relative to their income? These questions focus on protection, not premium collection.

Such measures are often dismissed as difficult to compute. In reality, much of the required data already exists – in regulatory filings, census household counts, and records of group insurance schemes. The goal need not be perfect precision. For public policy, understanding broad gaps in protection is far more important than tracking exact premium flows.

As long as India continues to rely on penetration and density as shorthand for insurance adequacy, the debate will remain confused. Premium growth risks being mistaken for progress, and industry expansion will be equated with social security.

Clear thinking begins with clear measurement. In life insurance, that means shifting the focus from how much money is collected to how well families are protected.
(T.C. Suseel Kumar is a former Managing Director of LIC and R. Sudhakar is a former Executive Director of LIC)

THE GIST

Insurance penetration and density are often misunderstood and do not reveal how many families are insured or whether they would be financially secure if the main earning member were to die.

The real issue is not reach but adequacy, as households may have life insurance but not enough cover to replace lost income, leaving them financially vulnerable.

Is compulsory voting feasible in the Indian context?

How can voter turnout be increased without making voting mandatory?

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:

The Election Commission has announced the poll schedule for five Assembly elections to be held in April-May 2026. In a separate hearing before the Supreme Court on a poll-related matter, the court raised questions regarding mandatory voting in elections.

What is the right to vote in India?

Article 326 of the Constitution grants every citizen the right to vote without any discrimination. It provides that any citizen who is not less than 18 years old and is not otherwise disqualified under the Constitution or any law on certain grounds is entitled to be registered as a voter.

Section 19 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, requires a citizen to be at least 18 years old and ordinarily resident in a constituency to be registered as an elector. Section 62 of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, provides the right to vote to every person whose name is entered in the electoral roll of a constituency. In various cases, the Supreme Court has held that the right to vote is a statutory right.

Should voting be made compulsory?

Voting is essential for a functional democracy, but it is neither a fundamental duty nor a legal duty in India. Proposals for compulsory voting have long been debated.

The Dinesh Goswami Committee on electoral reforms, set up in 1990, did not favour compulsory voting, citing practical

difficulties in implementation. Instead, it recommended improving voter participation through awareness campaigns.

The Law Commission, in its 255th report (2015), discussed the issue in detail. Compulsory voting does result in increased voter turnout by an average of about 7%. Nevertheless, this increase in participation is a direct corollary of the severity and strict enforcement of penalties for not voting.

Some democracies, such as Australia and several Latin American countries, have provisions for compulsory voting. In Australia, Argentina, and Brazil, voters may be fined if they fail to vote without valid reasons. In Peru, certain public goods and services are denied to non-voters.

Penalising non-voters by imposing fines

or restricting their access to government services is an extremely harsh measure that will not work in the Indian context. From a constitutional perspective, compulsory voting could be seen as violating the fundamental right to freedom of expression under Article 19(1).

What can be the way forward?

Low voter turnout can result in candidates winning by securing a minority of the total votes in a constituency.

However, as discussed in the Law Commission report, compulsory voting is neither desirable nor feasible in India. The solution lies in fostering enthusiasm amongst voters to exercise their right to vote through innovative campaigns, especially using social media.

For migrant workers, stricter implementation of the statutory holiday on the day of polling, coupled with an increase in transport facilities by running special buses and trains, can effectively increase participation. With the advent of newer technologies, robust and secure methods acceptable to all stakeholders for remote voting should be considered.
(Rangarajan R. is a former IAS officer and author of ‘Courseware on Polity Simplified.’ He currently trains at Officers IAS academy. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

The right to vote in India is a statutory right under Article 326 and the Representation of the People Act, and compulsory voting is neither a fundamental duty nor a legal duty.

While higher voter turnout shows a more representative democracy, compulsory voting is neither desirable nor feasible, and the focus should be on awareness, enthusiasm, and better access for voters.

CACHE



AP

As West Asia war threatens gas supply, remembering a gas grid India never built

India’s push for the National Coal Gasification Mission to secure energy independence recalls a visionary 1955 proposal by Syed Husain Zaheer; initially dismissed by policymakers, Zaheer’s plan for a national gas grid was vindicated by the 1973 global oil shock

Dinesh C Sharma

The ongoing war in West Asia has plunged the world into a deep energy crisis. In India, the availability of domestic fuel, LPG, has been hit due to the disruption in supplies from the Persian Gulf. The global energy crisis is reminiscent of the Oil Shock of 1973, when members of the Organisation of Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) cut oil production and slashed exports to protest the U.S.’s support for Israel in the Yom Kippur War. India responded by exploring alternative sources of energy, offshore oilfields in Bombay High, and experimenting with new technologies.

One technological option that found a second life this way was coal gasification. The idea of using gasified coal to meet some of India’s fuel needs first emerged in 1955 when Syed Husain Zaheer, director of the Regional Research Laboratory Hyderabad (RRLH) – now the CSIR-Indian Institute of Chemical Technology (IICT) – and later director-general of CSIR, submitted a plan to Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru for a cross-country national gas grid. The plan envisaged the use of fuel gas produced from gasifying of coal and its supply through pipelines for domestic and industrial use. Zaheer believed fuel gas of high calorific value could be produced by completely gasifying non-caking fuels such as shale coal, lignite, and bituminous coal, all found in India.

‘Town Gas Supply Scheme’
The technology involved gasifying coal using high pressure to form hydrocarbons and using oxygen to maintain a high thermal efficiency. It started with converting the sulphur present in the coal to hydrogen sulphide (H₂S) and small amounts of carbonyl sulphide (COS). Sulphur compounds are then removed from the gas stream and the separated acid gas is further processed to recover elemental sulphur.

The gas was further cleaned using water scrubbing to remove any remaining

particulate matter. In the 1940s, coal gasification was used at a commercial scale to provide town gas for street lighting in Europe and the U.S. But the concept’s techno-economic feasibility had yet to be established for Indian coal. Initially, Zaheer proposed a “Town Gas Supply Scheme” for Hyderabad based on gasifying coal found in the Singareni collieries and piping it to the city. If a gasification plant were established at Kothagudem, gas could be supplied not only to Hyderabad but also to towns along the 290-km-long route, per the plan. Based on surveys of fuel consumption, population and demand projections, family income, and fuel demand trends, Zaheer proposed a pressure gasification plant of 7.5 million cubic feet capacity, and suggested the gas pipeline could be laid along the railway track to facilitate easy maintenance and inspections.

Tough going
To demonstrate the technology’s feasibility, pilot studies were needed, which in turn required funding. Zaheer’s idea did not find any takers in the Central government or the CSIR. On the energy front, the policy focus at the time was on finding petroleum reserves and the development of nuclear energy, besides harnessing hydroelectric power from large dams. So in 1961, Zaheer urged Nehru to make a policy decision to establish several plants for manufacturing town gas based on coal gasification in select coal belts and linking them through a countrywide grid. Nehru liked the plan and observed that it was “a modern and more economical method, and it will bring enormous relief to the railways”. But the Ministry of Steel, Mines and Fuel pointed to the “infeasibility of the plan for transporting gas over long distances”. The Planning Commission, the Coal Council, and the CSIR, as well, remained cold to the proposal and were reluctant to fund a pilot plant to test coal gasification. When Nehru appointed Zaheer the CSIR director-general in 1962, Zaheer got a chance to implement his idea to develop

a pilot plant at RRLH. But the going was not easy as the plan required importing equipment. The wars of 1962 and 1965 did not help, delaying the procurement of machinery from Germany, and there was a massive cost overrun due to the devaluation of the rupee. The project came to a halt as soon as Zaheer’s term ended in 1966. His successor, Atma Ram, formed a committee to review the project. The panel gave an adverse report saying “it would not be advisable to establish and operate the plant in a manner proposed by RRLH” and suggested that the imported equipment be disposed of. Back then, there was strong opposition to CSIR labs setting up pilot plants to demonstrate technologies they had developed. This was despite the RRLH having already been running a successful semi-commercial pilot plant on another coal technology: low temperature carbonisation. Following the RRLH model, the National Chemicals Laboratory in Pune and the Indian Institute of Petroleum in Dehradun erected pilot plants as well.

‘Had we listened...’
After several reviews and controversies, the coal gasification project at RRLH received the go-ahead in 1972 and the crates of imported machinery were opened seven years after they had landed in Hyderabad. The project also received an unexpected boost: the Oil Shock in October 1973. The shortage of petroleum products sent the government scurrying for alternative fuels, recognising that “in the perspective of the country’s long-term energy requirements, consideration should be given to installing small to medium coal gasification plants to produce gas”. “It is now abundantly clear that a coal-based energy strategy is the only realistic course for us,” Prime Minister Indira Gandhi announced, recognising the past mistakes. In her inaugural speech at the Indian Science Congress session at Bhubaneswar in January 1977, she admitted, “Had we listened, in the early

’60s, to Dr. Husain Zaheer’s plea, and based our chemical feedstock policy not merely on oil but on the abundant coal reserves, we would have withstood the oil crisis with much less strain.” However, by the time RRLH erected the coal gasification pilot plant, the technology had moved to the next level. The pilot plant was used as a test bed for research on the integrated gasification combined cycle (IGCC), in collaboration with Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited (BHEL), which commissioned the first such plant in 1985. Unlike coal gasification to produce town gas, IGCC combines gas production from coal with electricity generation. The syngas produced by gasifying coal was used to run a power plant generating electricity. Gas-fired turbines were used to produce electricity and the excess heat was routed to steam-driven turbines.

Second wind
Although India began early with fuel R&D with national laboratories engaged in coal, petroleum, and geophysics research, the funding was suboptimal and projects lacked the necessary industrial linkages. Policymakers and competing interests failed to see the need for long-term research in this area. Interest in clean coal technologies has been revived as climate action has intensified. The National Coal Gasification Mission, which India launched in 2021, aims to gasify 100 million tonnes of coal by 2030. “The adoption of gasification technology in India will revolutionise the coal sector, reducing reliance on imports of natural gas, methanol, ammonia and other essential products,” according to a government statement. Massive investments to the tune of ₹85,000 crore have been committed to the Mission. Coal India Limited and BHEL also floated a new company, Bharat Coal Gasification & Chemicals Limited, in 2024 to work on clean coal technologies. (Dinesh C. Sharma is a New Delhi-based journalist and author, and has written books on India’s post-1947 science and technology journey)

THE DAILY QUIZ

A quiz to mark World Meteorological Day, observed annually on March 23

V. V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1
In which European city is the World Meteorological Organization headquartered?

QUESTION 2
Expand GRIB, the concise data format commonly used in meteorology to store historical and forecast weather data.

QUESTION 3
To a meteorologist, what is an ‘okta’, a scale of measurement?

QUESTION 4
What is the term for rain that falls from a cloud but evaporates before reaching the ground, seen as streaks under a cloud?

QUESTION 5
Parts of Kerala witnessed ‘blood rain’ as recently as 2012. What was the prime cause for such a freak downpour?

QUESTION 6
What is the everyday two-word term for a strong, high-altitude wind band that pilots use to save time and fuel on long flights?

QUESTION 7
The recurring natural phenomenon characterised by fluctuating ocean temperatures in the equatorial Pacific, coupled with changes in the atmosphere, is the ENSO. Expand ENSO.



Visual Question:
Name the Indian scientist who in his capacity as the chairman of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) received the Nobel Peace Prize, along with Al Gore, in 2007. REUTERS

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. The President of Iraq, Saddam Hussein, was captured by the U.S. military in December 2003. The operation was named after an American film set during a fictional World War 3. **Ans: Red Dawn** 2. In 2007, members of a private military firm, which was contracted by the U.S. government, killed 17 Iraqi civilians in Nisour Square in Baghdad. Four employees of the firm were later convicted in a U.S. Federal Court. What was the firm called then? And which U.S. President pardoned the four employees? **Ans: Blackwater; Donald Trump** 3. George W. Bush had insisted that Iraq was a “gathering threat” that had to be confronted. What did he say Iraq possessed? **Ans: Weapons of mass destruction** 4. This European country opposed President Bush’s policy on Iraq. Frustrated with its response, the U.S. ordered that the names of food items that featured the country’s name be changed in restaurants at the U.S. Capitol. **Ans: France** 5. Mr. Bush referred to an axis of evil — governments that he alleged had sponsored terrorism. Name the three countries he was referring to. **Ans: Iraq, Iran, North Korea** Visual: A tapestry copy of this painting can be found at the United Nations headquarters. **Ans: Guernica** **Early Birds:** Haridas Pal | Sunil Madhavan | Arun Kumar Singh | Dodo Jayaditya | Lalchand Bhutani



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

Organising the trip was like herding cats

She is in the doghouse for not calling her parents

S. Upendran

“Looks like the two-day conference has left you exhausted. What time did the delegates leave yesterday?”
“Some of them had a flight late in the evening. They left only around 9:00 PM.”
“How were the delegates? Did they enjoy themselves or did...”
“We had a little over 200 people, and they gave us a pretty hard time. Getting all of them into a room was like herding cats.”
“Herding cats? Never heard it before! What does it mean?”
“Have you ever managed to get a cat to do what you wanted it to?”
“I don’t think anyone has managed to do that! It does what it wants to, and not what someone tells it to!”
“Absolutely right! Cats have a mind of their own and, therefore, cannot be controlled. And that’s what the expression ‘herding cats’ means: trying to do the impossible.”
“In other words, when you attempt to ‘herd cats’, you’re trying to achieve the impossible. You’re trying to bring about order and discipline among people who do not have those qualities.”
“Very good! Here’s an example. Trying to get two small kids ready for school is like herding cats.”
“It certainly is. I’ve seen my sister struggle with her two brats! Here’s another example. The photographer said that getting all my classmates to stand still and look at the camera was like herding cats.”
“I can imagine. Getting twenty people to agree on a movie that we could all watch after dinner was like herding cats. Are you leaving already?”
“Have to do a bit of shopping. Would you like to come along?”
“You and shopping! That’s pretty unusual, indeed! What are you...”
“I need to buy a pair of sandals. After that, I plan to visit Sujatha and ask her about...”
“In that case, I’m not coming. She’s pretty mad at me.”
“Mad at you?”
“As you know, last week was her birthday. I forgot all about it because of the conference.”
“So, now you’re in the doghouse.”
“In the doghouse?”
“The expression suggests that you’re in trouble with someone. You’ve done something to upset the person.”
“The students landed themselves in the doghouse when the Principal caught them jumping over the wall.”
“Good example! If I don’t submit my project on time, I’ll be in the doghouse.”
“But tell me, what is the connection between being in a doghouse and being in trouble?”
“Where is the doghouse usually located?”
“A doghouse or a kennel is usually found outside a house – away from the warmth and...”
“Exactly! A dog is usually sent packing to its kennel when it has misbehaved or has done some mischief.”
“So, when do you think you’ll get back into Sujatha’s good books?”
“Not for a while, I’m afraid!”
“Till then, we’ll have to look for you in the doghouse, I guess!”
upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

Swanky:
imposingly fashionable and elegant

Synonyms: classy, trendy

Usage: They moved into a swanky new apartment.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/swanky

International Phonetic Alphabet: /swæŋki/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

From Page One

Will completely close
Hormuz Strait: Iran



A crater in a residential neighbourhood, following Iranian missile strikes in Arad, southern Israel, on Sunday. REUTERS

The military command said it would also strike Israel’s “power plants, energy, and information and communications technology (ICT) infrastructure”, along with power plants in regional countries hosting U.S. bases and companies with U.S. shareholders.

The Islamic Republic’s power grid is deeply intertwined with its energy sector. Striking major plants could trigger blackouts, crippling everything from pumps and refineries to export terminals and military command centres. While some Gulf desert states such as Saudi Arabia, Oman and the UAE have access to more than one sea to draw water from for desalination, Qatar, Bahrain and Kuwait are crowded along the shoreline of the Gulf with no other coastline.

Earlier in the day, Iranian media reports quoted Iran’s representative to the U.N. maritime agency as saying that the Strait of Hormuz remains open to all shipping except vessels linked to “Iran’s enemies”. Ali Mousavi’s comments came from an interview published on Friday by the Chinese news agency Xinhua, much before Mr. Trump’s ultimatum.

Meanwhile, Iran’s Parliament is mulling imposing tolls on shipping through the strait, with Speaker Ghalibaf saying maritime traffic would “not return to its pre-war status”.

Traffic through the vital strait has been brought to a near-standstill since the start of the war, that has so far killed over 2,000 people. A relatively small number of vessels have been able to transit it – around 5% of its pre-war volume, according to analytics firm Kpler. Iranian forces have attacked multiple vessels, saying they failed to heed “warnings” against transiting the waterway.

In recent days, Iran has allowed some vessels from countries it considers friendly to pass, while warning it would block ships from countries it says have joined the “aggression” against it.

Meanwhile, the exiled son of Iran’s last shah Reza Pahlavi called on Mr. Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu to refrain from targeting Iran’s civilian infrastructure, because it “belongs to the Iranian people and to the future of a free Iran.”

CPI(M) seeks time to
discuss Stalin’s offer

“The CPI(M) would like to continue in the DMK alliance. But, the Chief Minister has asked us to settle for five. However, the mandate of the CPI(M) State Committee is for six seats. We have told him we cannot come to a conclusion immediately. The Chief Minister wants us to take a favourable decision,” he said.

Asked whether the meeting would serve any purpose, since both sides were firm on their stands, Mr. Shanmugam said though both parties had been holding talks, a meeting with the Chief Minister had taken place only now. “As he has requested us, we have to respect his words and hold further talks,” he said.

Mr. Shanmugam said the Chief Minister himself had explained the difficulties arising from the allocation of three additional seats to the Congress and the inclusion of more parties in the alliance. “There is no secrecy in the talks. They are transparent,” he added.

To a question on whether the numbers were reduced because the CPI(M) had won only two seats last time, he said the party was not allotted constituencies where it had a strong base. “Had we been allotted seats in these districts, we would have won all six. There were many reasons that contributed to our defeat,” he said.

Mr. Shanmugam said the priority was to finalise seat-sharing, and the question of preferred constituencies would be discussed later.

Velmurugan’s party exits
DMK alliance for T.N. poll,
rules out joining NDA

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamizhaga Vazhvurimai Katchi founder, T. Velmurugan, on Sunday announced his party’s exit from the ruling DMK-led alliance in Tamil Nadu, accusing its leader of displaying a “big brother attitude”. Mr. Velmurugan was seen as the Vanniyar

face of the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance. The party was unhappy with the offer of a single seat, similar to what it received in 2016. He said he would take a decision on the future course after consulting with Periyarist organisations, smaller Tamil nationalist outfits, and other outfits that work for ordinary people.

‘Positive’ talks
with Kuki-Zo
Council, says
Manipur CM

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh on Sunday said that his meeting with leaders of the Kuki-Zo Council in Guwahati on Saturday was a step toward rebuilding trust between the Kuki-Zo and Meitei communities.

He told journalists in Imphal that the two communities need to “forgive and forget” to help restore normalcy in the State.

“The engagement with the Kuki-Zo Council was a positive beginning towards bridging the trust deficit and bringing lasting peace in Manipur,” he said, lamenting that displaced people were still unable to return to their native villages.

Mr. Singh noted that fear continues to affect the movement of people, particularly along National Highway 2, linking Imphal and Kohima, the capital of Nagaland. “How long can the central forces keep guarding people? We cannot move forward until we forget and forgive what has happened,” he said.

He said the Centre had assured that Manipur’s territorial integrity will not be compromised.

Tyagi joins
Rashtriya Lok
Dal after
leaving JD(U)

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Former Janata Dal (United) leader K.C. Tyagi on Sunday formally joined the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) in the presence of party chief and Union Minister Jayant Chaudhary in New Delhi.

Mr. Tyagi, a founding member of the JD(U), did not participate in the party’s membership renewal drive, signalling his exit from the JD(U) on March 17.

He had clarified at that time that he held no animosity regarding the JD(U) or Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, who has been elected to the Rajya Sabha, making it clear that he would not be remaining CM in the State in future.

Mr. Tyagi also addressed speculation regarding his parliamentary ambitions, denying that his exit was linked to a desire for a seat in the Rajya Sabha. “There is not a single instance of me trying for a Rajya Sabha ticket. Even in 2013, Nitish Kumar called me and offered me a ticket,” he said.

Modi assesses impact of
West Asia conflict on India

Cabinet Committee on Security discusses diversifying sources of imports, including fertilizers, chemicals, pharmaceuticals, and petrochemicals; PM directs ‘whole-of-government approach’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

As tensions continue to escalate in West Asia, threatening energy and commodity supply routes, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday chaired a meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) to review the situation and suggest mitigating measures.

A government statement said the meeting assessed the ongoing conflict’s short-, long-, and medium-term impact.

Furthermore, the committee also discussed potential measures, both immediate and long-term, to manage the crisis.

“The ongoing conflict in West Asia will have significant short, medium and long-term impact on the global economy. Its effect on India was assessed, and counter-measures, both immediate and long-term, were discussed,” the statement said.

Mr. Modi directed that a Group of Ministers (GoM) and a group of secretaries be formed to work exclu-



Taking stock: Prime Minister Narendra Modi chairs a meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Security to review the situation, in view of the escalating tensions in West Asia, in New Delhi on Sunday. DPR PMO

sively on a “whole-of-government approach” to the crisis.

The Prime Minister urged sectoral groups to work in consultation with all stakeholders.

Alternate sources

The CCS discussed diversifying sources of major imports, including fertilizers, chemicals, pharmaceuticals, and petrochemicals. Fertilizers assume signif-

icance ahead of the coming kharif season, and in view of the disruptions to natural gas imports after Tehran’s missile attacks devastated energy infrastructure in Qatar, which is among the biggest importers of LNG globally.

“The measures taken in the last few years to maintain adequate stocks of fertilizers will ensure timely availability and food security. Alternate sources of

fertilizers were also discussed to ensure continued availability in the future,” the statement read.

The Cabinet committee also called for ensuring an “adequate” supply of coal stocks at all power plants.

The carbon commodity becomes essential with power demand expected to peak in summers and the potential constraints of natural gas supplies due to the ongoing conflict.

Auction of 19 blocks
of critical minerals
set to begin today

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The government will launch the seventh tranche of auctions for critical and strategic minerals on Monday, placing 19 blocks on sale across several States.

The development assumes significance as the government aims to bolster India’s self-reliance in clean energy, advanced technologies, fertilizers, and strategic sectors amid global supply chain disruptions.

So far, the government has conducted six rounds of auctions, with 46 critical and strategic mineral blocks already sold. “Building on this momentum, the seventh tranche will offer 19 blocks across several States under mining lease and composite licence,” the Union Ministry of Mines said in a statement.

Critical minerals are important for the country’s economic development and mineral security. The global transition to-



Critical minerals are crucial for India’s economic development and mineral security.

wards clean energy and advanced technologies has significantly increased the demand for minerals, including lithium, graphite, rare earth elements, tungsten, vanadium, titanium, and other rare metals.

“Union Minister of Coal and Mines G. Kishan Reddy, along with the Minister of State for Coal and Mines Satish Chandra Dubey, will launch the 7th tranche of auction of critical and strategic mineral blocks on March 23,” the Ministry said.

BJD ready for
legal battle to
ensure 6 MLAs
are disqualified

Press Trust of India
BHUBANESWAR

The Opposition BJD on Sunday said the party is ready to go for a legal battle to ensure that its six MLAs, who have been suspended for allegedly voting in favour of the BJP in the recent Rajya Sabha poll to four seats, are disqualified from the Odisha Assembly.

Addressing a press conference here, BJD spokesperson Lenin Mohanty said the party was “mentally prepared to carry this battle till the last point”. “If required, the BJD is ready to take the matter to the Supreme Court and ensure that they are disqualified from the House,” he said.

Mr. Mohanty’s comment comes a day after the BJD had suspended six of its MLAs for “cross-voting”.

The suspended legislators are Chakramani Kanhar (Baliguda), Naba Kishor Mallick (Jayadev), Souvic Biswal (Choudwar Cuttack), Subasini Jena (Basta), Ramakanta Bhoi (Tirtol) and Devi Ranjan Tripathy (Banki).

Justice Bhuyan flags
reticence shown by
courts to grant bail

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Supreme Court judge, Justice Ujjal Bhuyan, on Sunday said there were many within the judiciary who continue to suffer from the “more loyal than the king syndrome”, while pointing to the reticence shown by courts to grant bail, leading to prolonged incarceration for undertrials.

“The judiciary must remain judiciary. Judiciary can neither be an eternal critic nor a cheerleader. It is the sentinel on the *qui vive* (alert),” Justice Bhuyan said at the First Supreme Court Bar Association National Conference 2026 on the topic ‘The Role of Judiciary in Viksit Bharat’ in Bengaluru.

“For trivial matters, such as public demonstrations, agitations, even by students, sometimes even for putting up memes and social media posts, FIRs (First Information Reports) are registered, and investigations go on. Matters

Modi sets new
record with
8,931 days in
public office

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday became the longest-serving head of a government in India, serving 8,931 days in office, first as the Chief Minister of Gujarat and now as the Prime Minister. He has surpassed former Sikkim Chief Minister Pawan Chamling’s record of 8,930 days in office.

Cabinet colleagues congratulated Mr. Modi, with Defence Minister Rajnath Singh lauding his “pure devotion to the nation and its people” and Home Minister Amit Shah terming it a “milestone rooted in service, hard work and unwavering commitment”.

“Modiji’s decades of *sewa* have shaped an era of their own. Whether it is giving the poor their rights, setting new landmarks in development or enhancing the nation’s pride on global platforms, the Modi Era has transformed India unrecognisably,” Mr. Shah said in a post on X.

Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari said it “stands as a testament to enduring public trust and a lifelong mission devoted to Bharat’s growth and progress”.

India watches closely as Gor visits Sri Lanka, Maldives

NEWS ANALYSIS

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

United States Ambassador to India Sergio Gor’s visit to Sri Lanka – his first visit in the region in his role as U.S. Special Envoy for South Asia – is a “quiet strategic signal”, said experts, as it comes amid the war in West Asia, and U.S. action in the Indian Ocean.

While the Narendra Modi government has made no comment about the visit, Mr. Gor met National Security Adviser Ajit Doval before embarking on the six-day (March 19-24) regional tour of Sri Lanka and the Maldives, and the government is understood to be watching its outcomes carefully.

India’s response to Mr. Gor’s position contrasts with the last time the U.S. nominated a Special Envoy for the region. In 2009, when the Obama administration nominated Richard Holbrooke, the government had protested vociferously, calling a “broad mandate” for the envoy “risky” and “interfering”, according to diplomatic cables released by Wikileaks in 2016, and the U.S. had backtracked, appointing him and subsequently Zalmay Khalilzad only as Special Representatives for Afghanistan and Pakistan (SRAPs).

Prior to Mr. Gor, South Asia was dealt with bilaterally via U.S. Ambassadors in each capital, and by the Assistant Secretary of State for South and Central Asia, a position currently occu-

pied by S. Paul Kapur.

This time around, Mr. Gor has a much broader mandate, with U.S. President Donald Trump appointing him as his Special Envoy to South and Central Asia in August 2025. Mr. Gor has already made visits to Central Asian capitals as Special Envoy, and also travelled to Bhutan last week, although that was in his capacity as Ambassador to Bhutan, where he is concurrently accredited. All eyes will be on whether Mr. Gor would travel next to Pakistan and Bangladesh, and whether his role as Special Envoy would also include any attempts to mediate between India and its neighbours, which it would oppose. In addition, experts and officials said Mr. Gor’s visit is being tracked particularly



Sergio Gor

as South Asia appears to be drawn in to the U.S.-Israel war with Iran, with a U.S. submarine bombing the Iranian ship *IRIS Dena*, and the latest Iranian strikes towards the U.S.-United Kingdom’s Diego Garcia base.

“Sergio Gor’s visit to Colombo is best read as a quiet strategic signal rather than a substantive break-

through: the United States is reasserting a calibrated presence in the Indian Ocean at a moment when tensions in [West Asia] are spilling into the maritime space,” said former Foreign Secretary and Ambassador to the U.S. and China Nirupama Menon Rao, who pointed out that Sri Lanka had balanced the optics of the visit carefully.

Visiting the Colombo Port, Mr. Gor said in a post that it was “clear how this critical hub connects South Asia to global markets – and why maritime security here matters”. Sri Lankan President Anura Kumara Dissanayake also “briefed” Mr. Gor’s delegation on the “ongoing conflict situation in the Middle East, as well as the challenges faced by the country in light of these deve-

lopments”. Mr. Gor’s travel to Sri Lanka came two weeks after the Iranian ship *IRIS Dena* was torpedoed by a U.S. submarine close to Sri Lankan waters, and Mr. Dissanayake refused U.S. warplanes permission to land in Sri Lanka’s Mattala airport during the war.

Former Sri Lankan Foreign Secretary and Ambassador to the U.S. Prasad Kariyawasam said that the visit of Mr. Gor was a positive development.

“It’s very good that high-level contacts are maintained actively with the USA in the context of the war, given that U.S. is a leading maritime power in the Indian Ocean and that Iran is highly connected with Indian Ocean countries”, Mr. Kariyawasam told *The Hindu*.

Cong. final list names seven for Assam polls

The Congress on Sunday announced its fifth and final list of seven candidates for the Assam Assembly election. With this, the party has declared candidates for 101 of the 126 seats in the State Assembly.

Among the candidates declared in the final list are Joseph Hasda from the

Gossaigaon seat, Birkhang Boro from Dotma-ST, Rajat Kanti Saha from Bijni and Anchula Gwara Daimary from the Bhergaon seat.

In an official statement, the party also declared Narayan Adhikari as its candidate from the Mazbat, Nirmal Langthasa from the Haflong-ST and Amar Chand Jain from the Katigorah Assembly constituency.

The elections to the 126-member Assam assembly will be held on April 9. Votes will be counted on May 4.



Congress cadre at a rally in Nagaon, Assam, recently.

Bengal likely to get 2,400 CAPF companies

About 2,400 companies of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) are likely to be deployed in West Bengal for the upcoming Assembly election.

The Chief Electoral Office (CEO) of West Bengal has set up a joint committee to oversee the deployment based on the assessments of

vulnerability and sensitivity across polling areas. The committee held a meeting on Saturday at the CEO's office to decide on the number of personnel required in each Assembly constituency.

Since Saturday morning, Police Commissioners and Superintendents of Police have started visiting local police stations across the State to take stock of the ground situation.

About 480 companies of central forces have already been deployed by March 10.



The BJP's agenda was to use the SIR process to defeat Mamata Banerjee since she has defeated the saffron party for the last 15 years

SAGARIKA GHOSE
Trinamool Rajya Sabha member

7 candidates on Trinamool list for Assam

The Trinamool Congress has fielded an Assam MLA who stirred up a hornets' nest by suggesting a Miya Museum at a cultural centre in Guwahati five years ago. Sherman Ali Ahmed figured on the list of seven candidates announced by the Trinamool on Sunday. He is contesting from Mandia.



She [Mamata Banerjee] is emerging victorious, no matter how many officials are reshuffled by the Election Commission in collusion with the BJP

AKHILESH YADAV
Samajwadi Party leader



Poll rally: Mamata Banerjee addressing party workers in Kolkata on Sunday.

Mamata begins Bhabanipur campaign with workers' meet

Shiv Sahay Singh
Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister and Trinamool Congress chairperson Mamata Banerjee on Sunday began her campaign for the Bhabanipur Assembly seat with a workers' meeting.

The meeting was held at Ahindra Mancha, with eight councillors of the Trinamool, including Minister Firhad Hakim, who is also a councillor from the area, among those present. With Bharatiya Janata Party leader Suwendu Adhikari contesting against the Trinamool chairperson, the Assembly seat in south Kolkata has become a prestige fight for both the parties.

The Trinamool shared photographs of the party chairperson addressing the meeting from its social media handles. "Today, Smt. @MamataOfficial set the tone for the battles ahead. Addressing party workers at Chetla, she called for relentless ground mobilisation, discipline, and an unbreakable connect with every household in Bengal," the West Bengal's ruling party said.

"At a time when Bangla-Birodhi forces are resorting to conspiracies, misinformation, and external interference, the message was unequivocal. We will not yield an inch."

The constituency located in the heart of Kolkata has electors from different communities, including Hindus, Sikhs, and Jains. Both Ms. Banerjee and her nephew, party general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, reside in the constituency. The Chief Minister has won three consecutive elections from the constituency in 2011, 2016, and 2021.

After losing to Mr. Adhikari in Nandigram in the 2021 election by a margin of 1,956 votes, Ms. Banerjee had contested and won from Bhabanipur in a byelection held in September 2021 by a margin of 58,832 votes, securing 72% of the total votes polled.

In the 2026 Assembly election, the contest has become interesting for two more reasons. First, the BJP had narrowed the gap with the Trinamool in the Bhabanipur Assembly seat during the 2024 Lok Sabha election, with the Trinamool's lead dropping to 8,297 votes in 2024 as against 58,832 votes in the 2021 Assembly election. In five wards of the Kolkata Municipal Corporation (63, 70, 71, 72, and 74), the BJP polled more votes while the Trinamool led in three wards – 73, 77, and 82.

The second important issue has been deletion of voters during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise. The SIR process, which has been controversial from the start in the State, saw the deletion of about 47,000 electors and another 14,000 being put to judicial adjudication in the constituency.

Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee had earlier this month said that despite the deletions due to SIR, she would win from Bhabanipur.

"I will win from Bhabanipur even if there is only one voter left on the voter list," the Chief Minister said on March 3, while addressing a gathering here.

Mr. Adhikari, who started the campaign a few days ago in Bhabanipur, has been playing up his chances of winning against the Chief Minister. The BJP leader is also contesting from Nandigram.

Amid the challenge from Bhabanipur and the first supplementary list of electors under adjudication set to be published on Monday, the Chief Minister postponed her visit to north Bengal. Instead of Tuesday, she will start campaigning in north Bengal on Wednesday.

BJP will draw a blank this time too

Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan does not see defections from the Left helping either the BJP or the Cong.; The Congress is BJP's 'B team', he says and rules out the BJP's Christian outreach working in its favour; The Left govt. should continue for the State to be in step with modern era, he adds

INTERVIEW

Pinarayi Vijayan

S. Anandan

Kerala Chief Minister and CPI(M) Polit Bureau member Pinarayi Vijayan is leading the Left Democratic Front's (LDF) charge on the hustings as the coalition seeks a third consecutive term in the State Assembly election on April 9. Just shy of 81, he exudes confidence of a win, pities the Congress for being the 'B team of the BJP' and predicts the BJP drawing a blank yet again, as he sits down for an interview with The Hindu at Pinarayi in his constituency, Dharmadam. Edited excerpts:

A large number of incumbent MLAs have been renominated by the Left front. No anti-incumbency?

There's no anti-incumbency because people feel that the government has strived to implement to the best of its abilities what the people wanted. Ten years ago, Kerala was in a shambles, but we brought about a sea change in all sectors. Now, our Vision 2031 delineates the achievable goals in each sector in order to de-

velop Kerala in step with the modern times.

If no institution from Kerala featured among the 100 top institutions nationally in 2016, eighteen Kerala colleges are on the list now. It's the result of active interventions, which call for a continuance.

We have fostered research, modern-day courses and skill development of the youth, linking the academia to industries. Our industry-friendliness is attracting top players from all over the world and everyone, except red industries, is welcome. We have a pre-eminent startup ecosystem.

But despite this, the Left suffered a jolt in the recent local body polls.

Each election follows a unique pattern. It was a local election, and we suffered setbacks at a few places which do not reflect the public sentiment across the State. We sense a favourable atmosphere now.

The BJP advances the 'develop Kerala' slogan but the Left accuses the Centre of stifling the State.

While it harps on 'develop Kerala' now, has the Centre done anything to develop Kerala? Despite repeated appeals and the stupendous feats in public health-



care, we have not got an AI-IMS. When the State was hit by disasters, the Centre not only turned its back, but blocked support from the countries which share a deep bond with Kerala. Did any other State in India receive such ignominious treatment in the face of a disaster? It was just us. Didn't it demonstrate a mentality that wanted to see the State perish?

The Centre sided with those who opposed on political grounds the K-Rail project meant to augment our transport infrastructure.

The State is denied its rightful share of taxes and our borrowing limit has been slashed considerably. Doesn't all this smack of vendetta?

What's your take on the BJP's Christian outreach and the Left's relationship with the community?

We have a good relationship with all communities. All sections of Christians, together forming a substantial community in the State, have a good relationship with the government. The BJP may harbour many desires, but nothing is going to materialise and there will be no consolidation in its favour.

How do you stop the BJP in its tracks? Who is better poised to do that, the Congress or the Left?

The Congress is unable to do that. It acts as the BJP's B-team, even nationally. Only the Left has steadfastly resisted the BJP, which it will continue even more vigorously. And the BJP is unlikely to make any electoral gain this time either.

Nationally, only a united front is possible against the BJP, but the Congress always foils such bids by vi-

DMK's allies find themselves politically squeezed

D. Suresh Kumar
CHENNAI

Alliances forged during elections often unravel within months of the results being declared. Parties routinely downplay such arrangements, describing them as mere "seat-sharing" exercises. This pattern has largely held true in Tamil Nadu as well.

An exception, however, has been the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance under Chief Minister M.K. Stalin, which has held together for nearly nine years. Its durability stems in large part from a shared anti-Hindutva ideological alignment among its constituents. Yet, this cohesion has not come without a cost. The ongoing seat-sharing negotiations for the April 23 Assembly elections have exposed underlying tensions, particularly among the alliance's smaller partners, who view the allocations as increasingly restrictive.

Of flexibility & firmness

In the case of its principal ally, the Congress, the DMK leadership had shown flexibility, conceding three additional seats and even a Rajya Sabha berth. This accommodation came despite publicly critical remarks by individuals close to Congress leader Rahul Gandhi. The Congress also exploited



Chief Minister M.K. Stalin with leaders of DMK alliance parties at an event in Kalaivanar Arangam in Chennai in June 2025.

the option of aligning with actor C. Joseph Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam to assert itself in negotiations.

By contrast, the DMK has adopted a firmer approach with its other allies, even reducing their seat allocations. The CPI, the CPI (M), the Viduthalaai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK), and the MDMK had aligned with the DMK in 2017. They found common ground in opposing the BJP's attempts to expand its footprint in Tamil Nadu, exploiting fissures in the AIADMK following Chief Minister Jayalalithaa's death in 2016.

These parties, along with smaller outfits such as the Manithaneya Makkal Katchi and Tamilaga Vazhuvirimai Katchi, played a significant role in shaping an anti-Narendra Modi political narrative by mobilising protests against various central policies and projects. Mr. Stalin successfully built on this platform to

Smaller parties found common ground with the DMK in opposing the BJP's attempts to grow in Tamil Nadu

channelise, anchor and capitalise on the political sentiment, benefiting the alliance as a whole in successive elections since 2019.

In the previous Assembly election, the CPI, the CPI (M), the VCK and the MDMK had settled for six seats each, even if they felt the number did not reflect their political weight. They justified the compromise as necessary "to keep the BJP at bay". This time, however, expectations were higher. Having remained loyal to the alliance, these parties anticipated a more favourable arrangement.

Instead, they have been offered fewer seats, with the DMK citing the need to accommodate new en-

trants. The CPI has been allotted five seats, the MDMK four (with three to be contested under the DMK's symbol), and the IUML two – down from three previously.

The Tamilaga Vazhuvirimai Katchi leader T. Velmurugan on Sunday exited the alliance, dissatisfied with its allocation of just one seat.

Lack of alternatives

For many of these long-standing partners, the current exercise has proven politically constraining. Deprived of feasible alternatives and growth opportunities, they are compelled to accept the terms set by the dominant partner. Questions have been raised, privately, about the DMK's decision to accommodate late Vijayakant's DMDK by offering it a Rajya Sabha seat and an undisclosed number of Assembly seats. This is seen by allies as disproportionate to the DMDK's diminished vote share of below half-a-percent.

Allies remain puzzled as to why a party that has shifted alliance positions with ease is being extended a privilege not afforded to more ideologically consistent partners.

The DMK's broader objective is clear: to contest a sufficiently large number of seats, 165 to 175, to secure a majority on its own. This goal inevitably limits

the space available for smaller partners.

The VCK, which has consistently articulated the concerns of Scheduled Castes and has been at the forefront of organising conferences against far-right positions, had sought eight to 10 seats in line with its recent growth in northern Tamil Nadu. The DMK, initially believed to be open to allocating eight seats, scaled it down to seven. On Saturday, party leader Thol. Thirumavala- n urged cadre to be prepared to accept the offer, emphasising the party's decisions are guided by long-term credibility, not short-term electoral gains.

The CPI(M), too, has found the reduced allocation difficult to accept. It held an extended meeting of its State secretariat on Saturday, attended by general secretary M.A. Baby. It entered discussions on Sunday with a mandate to seek at least the six seats it had contested last time. However, Mr. Stalin remained firm on placing it on a par with the CPI. For now, State secretary M. Shanmugam has said the offer would be discussed further within the party.

As the election approaches, the alliance leadership is likely to project unity and rally behind a common political narrative. However, the discontent at the cadre level may prove difficult to manage.

Defeat of BJP must to save Assam, says citizen forum

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Days after activist-turned-MLA Akhil Gogoi's Rajior Dal joined the Congress-led bloc, a citizens' collective said the Opposition unity must translate into an anti-BJP verdict in the April 9 Assembly election in Assam.

The Assam Nagorik Samilani, led by academic Hiren Gohain and retired IPS officer Harekrishna Deka, said that the BJP's divisive politics had "hollowed out the Assamese identity from within". It said that the BJP-led government handed over the State's vital natural resources to multinationals over the past 10 years.

"The rule of law has vanished; the Chief Minister's word now passes for law. The people of Assam have no choice but to remove this government, and another five years in power would spell disaster for ordinary citizens," it said in a statement on Sunday.

Insisting that six Opposition parties striking a seat-sharing deal was a relief for the people seeking an alternative, it said their unity "must ignite a mass awakening" to defend democracy and confront the BJP.

INBRIEF



PM writes to Nitish on Bihar Divas, hails State's rich culture

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday wrote to Chief Minister Nitish Kumar on occasion of Bihar Divas, extending his heartfelt greetings to the people of the State. Mr. Modi, in his three-page letter, said that Bihar Divas is a day to celebrate Bihar's rich history, its potential, and its traditions. "It is an opportunity to recall Bihar's invaluable contribution to India's robust identity. Since ancient times, the land of Bihar has enriched society through knowledge, spirituality, and moral values. The teachings imparted by Lord Buddha on this very soil remain an integral part of global consciousness today, continuing to guide humanity," he wrote in the letter.

'Cash irregularities': Guna SP, Sidhi Collector shunted out

Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Sunday shunted out Sidhi Collector Swarochit Somvanshi and Guna Superintendent of Police Ankit Soni following complaints and a probe into alleged cash irregularities. "Chief Minister Yadav directed the immediate removal of Sidhi Collector Swarochit Somvanshi and the suspension of district cooperative bank general manager P S Dhanwal due to the complaints received," an official statement said. Mr. Somvanshi has been replaced by IAS officer Vikas Mishra, it added.

Bill to amend Transgender Persons Act faces criticism

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Opposition leaders and activists on Sunday spoke out against the Bill to amend the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019, which proposes to remove the right to a self-perceived gender identity and introduces the requirement for a medical board to determine whether a person is transgender based on a new definition of "transgender person". At a public hearing held at the Press Club of India, Rajya Sabha members from the RJD, Congress, and the CPI(M) spoke against the Bill and said there was an attempt to coordinate a strategy to oppose it within Parliament. RJD MP Manoj Kumar Jha said the only explanation for such a "regressive" Bill was that "this government's thinking is regressive".

Even Muslim-majority nations don't allow *namaz* on roads, says RSS leader

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

"Even Muslim-majority countries do not allow prayers on roads and have designated places for worship," Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) national publicity in-charge Sunil Ambekar said in an interview with *The Hindu*. Mr. Ambekar made the statement while responding to questions on how incidents in BJP-ruled States – such as FIRs over *namaz* on roads, Iftar on a boat in the Ganga, or the Char Dham temples asking for 'Sanatani' affidavits– impact the RSS's message of unity in diversity. "When the government restricts *namaz* on roads, it should be seen as a law-and-order decision, not a religious restriction," he said. On the temple issue, he

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Expressing concern that actual procurement of rice and wheat has consistently remained below estimates in recent years and below targets in States such as Bihar, Gujarat, Punjab, and Uttar Pradesh, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Consumer Affairs, Food, and Public Distribution, headed by DMK MP Kanimozhi, has asked the Union Food Ministry to strengthen its procurement planning and coordinate with States to minimise the gap between estimated and actual procurement of both the food grains. In a report on the Demands for Grants of the Department of Food and Public Distribution, the panel noted that since 2022-23, the procurement of wheat and rice had been less than 30% of the total production. "Moreover, actual procurement of wheat has been 76.71%, 71.35% and 87.29% of the estimate for



The panel flagged that procurement of rice and wheat has remained below target in Bihar, Gujarat, Punjab, and U.P. PTI

the years 2023-24, 2024-25 and 2025-26 respectively. Similarly, the actual procurement of rice has been less than target since 2022-23," the report revealed. During the kharif marketing season of 2024-25, the procurement of rice from Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, and Punjab was 25.60 lakh tonnes, 0.003 lakh tonnes, and 116.13 lakh tonnes against the target of 35 lakh tonnes, 5.29 lakh tonnes, and 124 lakh tonnes, respectively, the panel said. Similarly, during the rabi marketing season of 2025-26, the procurement of wheat was less than the

target in the States of Bihar, Gujarat, Punjab, and Uttar Pradesh, it added. **Multiple factors at play** The government told the panel that any fluctuation in estimated production and actual production resulted in variation in procurement. "Procurement depends on multiple factors like production, market surplus, minimum support price (MSP), prevailing market rates, demand-supply situation, and participation of private traders, etc., the government informed. Noting these factors, the panel asked the govern-

ment to strengthen its procurement planning and coordination with the States to minimise the gap between estimated and actual procurement of wheat and rice. "While noting the Department's submission that procurement levels are influenced by multiple factors, the Committee is concerned that actual procurement has consistently remained below estimates in recent years and below targets in several States," the report said. The panel asked the Union government to review the methodology used for estimating procurement requirements, enhance real-time monitoring of production and market arrivals, and work closely with State governments – particularly in States where procurement has significantly fallen short of targets – to ensure that procurement operations are more realistic, responsive and effective. It asked the government to apprise it of the corrective measures taken on the suggestions.

Details sought on inquiry, prosecution wings of the Lokpal

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

A parliamentary committee has sought details of what is being done to fully operationalise the inquiry and prosecution wings of the Lokpal, over a decade after a law governing it was enacted. The law governing the anti-corruption ombudsman – The Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act 2013 – came into force on January 1, 2014. However, it began functioning only on March 27, 2019, following the appointment of its chairperson and members. To discharge its statutory functions, Section 11 of the Act obligates the Lokpal to constitute an inquiry wing to be led by a director of inquiry for conducting a preliminary inquiry into corruption-related offences. The Lokpal Act also has a provision for the constitution of a prosecution wing headed by the 'director of prosecution' for the prosecution of public servants. **Process ongoing** In its latest report, the Department-related Parlia-

The panel noted that matters relating to prosecution are being handled through the CBI mentary Standing Committee on Personnel, Public Grievances, Law and Justice noted that the appointment of the director of inquiry and staffing of the inquiry wing in accordance with the approved organogram is still in process. The committee, therefore, desires to be apprised of the present status of appointment of the director and the steps taken to operationalise the inquiry wing in its full statutory form, while ensuring coordination with existing investigative agencies, it said. The panel, in its 160th report, said the prosecution wing of the Lokpal had been formally constituted through an order dated June 6, 2025. The committee noted that, at present, matters relating to prosecution are being handled through the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), which has its own prosecution mechanism.

House panel for fee rationalisation, greater inclusivity in Sainik Schools

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

A parliamentary standing committee on defence asked the Defence Ministry to address the issue of high annual fees in Sainik Schools on a priority basis. The committee recommended creation of a dedicated fund to provide financial assistance or special concessions to students, particularly those from middle class and lower middle class or low income families. The aim is to ensure that deserving candidates, once selected, are not forced to give up their admission due to unaffordable fee structure, and can pursue their aspiration of studying in Sainik Schools without financial constraints. It has also recommended certain reforms in Sainik Schools, calling for greater inclusivity, fee rationalisation, and curriculum modernisation to en-



Students of Sainik School, Goalpara take aim in a shooting range, in this file photo. RITU RAJ KONWAR

sure wider access and future-ready education for cadets. While noting the existing reservation for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Other Backward Classes, the committee emphasised the need to extend opportunities to students from economically weaker sections irrespective of their social background. It urged the Ministry to review the Sainik Schools Society Rules & Regulations, 1997 to intro-

duce provisions for fee exemption or subsidies, enabling deserving students to access quality education and serve the nation. **Heavy burden** The panel also flagged concerns over the high annual fee structure, which includes expenses for tuition, boarding, uniforms, and other charges, along with a yearly 10% hike. It observed that this imposes a heavy burden on middle and lower income families

and risks excluding meritorious candidates. In addition, the House committee called for periodic updates to the curriculum to align with evolving defence and technology landscapes. It stressed the inclusion of subjects such as artificial intelligence, cyber and space warfare, drone systems, quantum technology and energy geopolitics to equip cadets with contemporary knowledge and skills. The panel was informed that, with rising enrolment of girl cadets in Sainik Schools, proactive steps are being taken to ensure safe, hygienic, and suitable residential facilities in every school. One all-girls' school has also been approved at Mathura, which will be started along with some private trusts like Rani Chennamma Sainik School in Kittur, where only the girl students will be trained.

THE HINDU

CROSSWORD

14748

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY

13. Means of communication that's out of reach in Dindigul (5)

14. Part of club is super cool according to the Reverend (8)

16. One regularly wetting the bed? (8)

18. Break eggs from one end to the other (5)

20. First of all, bro, men want sexy cars (1,1,1,1)

21. Negotiates with members involved in insurance (6,4)

23. Anybody could be putting tight noose around me (7)

24. Develop an American company, say (7)

25. Explosive report mainly implicates judge (6)

26. Order a fancy big fan (6)

Down

1. Heard you and I have to make up (5)

2. Figure of dragon on a gong (7)

3. Perhaps Korean man wanting anaesthesia is treated (4,5)

5. Pay when you eat lunch (5)

6. Washing hair in Singapore sucks! (7)

7. Timid one initially gets beaten in prison (5,4)

10. A thin girl injured in a minor fall (5,4)

13. Ahem...er... I can explain! (4,2,3)

15. Spooner's fans want the effect of a good punch perhaps (9)

17. Locked up Napoleon in America perhaps (7)

19. One is naturally alarming (7)

21. What makes the coating of confectionery sweet? (5)

22. This might keep you warm in East End's diner (5)

SUDOKU

1 5 7 6 8 3 2 5 1 2 2 8 9 5 6

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Hanuman's noble mission

Sundara Kanda is so named because it narrates Hanuman's remarkable and noble mission to search for and discover Sita. Hanuman possessed unwavering confidence that he would certainly succeed in locating Sita, particularly because Rama had chosen him for this sacred task and entrusted him with his ring, which was to be delivered to Sita as a symbol of recognition and assurance. Hanuman's confidence was further strengthened by Jambavan's encouragement. Sri Hariji explained that with renewed determination, Hanuman compared himself to Rama's arrow, which travels swiftly, strikes its intended target, and faithfully returns to its master. Hanuman resolved to cross the vast ocean with the same speed and precision to accomplish his task. Just as Rama's arrow bears the mark and authority of its master, Hanuman too carried the divine mark of Rama through his constant devotion and the sacred chanting of "Rama."

Hanuman possessed unwavering faith in the sacred ring given to him by Rama, which bore the divine name. With the blessings of Rama, Hanuman courageously crossed the vast ocean with remarkable ease. After sincerely praying to Sita, he soon found her in Ashokavana. Thereafter, Hanuman resolved to return to Rama as quickly as possible to deliver the joyful news of Sita's whereabouts, keeping Rama constantly in his thoughts.

Rama's act of giving the ring to Hanuman symbolises the profound concept of "Abhaya Pradanam," which means granting protection and removing fear. In this episode, Sita entrusts Hanuman with her head ornament as a token to convey her message and "Saranagati" to Rama.

Personal loan at lower cost

Santosh Agarwal

Personal loans are unsecured as lenders take risk by disbursing funds, without any collateral or guarantee. In this scenario, your credit score, which reflects past repayment behaviour, helps lenders in assessing the risk involved and taking a decision, as well as determining the interest rates in case the loan application is approved. Exhibiting strong creditworthiness generally helps borrowers get loans at better rates and terms.

Along with credit score, other pertinent factors also influence the likelihood of a borrower landing an offer with the best rates.

These factors include existing relationships with lenders, borrowers' debt-to-income ratio, income profile and more.

Maintain high credit score
Credit score is one of the primary metrics lenders use for pricing a loan. Credit score shows how dependable you are as a borrower.

Lenders usually prefer borrowers with scores above 750, signifying lower risk.

To maintain a good score, ensure timely repayments of all existing dues, keep your credit utilization ratio low and refrain from applying for multiple credit products within a short span of time. Consistent and disciplined behaviour helps build a strong credit score, giving you better leverage while negotiating interest rates and processing charges with lenders.

Compare multiple lenders
Comparing offers across lenders helps you easily scan and identify the best-suited offer. A simultaneous view helps in better analysis of rates and charges levied. A smarter approach involves comparing multiple loan offers in one place at financial marketplace platforms, rather than applying directly to several lenders, to minimise impact on the credit profile.

Relationship with lenders
Enquiring from the lender you have an existing relationship with can be a cost-effective way to borrow. Lenders extend pre-approved offers to select existing customers based on internal risk assessment. Your banking history or transaction record establishes the confidence of the lender in you. Because of this lower perceived risk, the lenders often provide better interest rates, faster approval, minimal documentation and sometimes lower processing charges on pre-approved loans.

Seasonal/festive offers
Keep an eye out for special offers from lenders from time to time. These personal loan offers are usually provided at discounted interest rates or with waived processing fees. Such offers are usually introduced during festive seasons for a limited period. Borrowers can time borrowing plans around such times to capitalise on these promotional offers and maximise their benefits.

Higher repayment prowess
Providing lenders with additional proof that shows higher repayment capability can also help in both the approval process and getting lower interest rates.

For instance, proof showing high income reduces the risk involved, as it shows higher repayment capacity. A higher income indicates a borrower is more likely to handle monthly repayments without financial strain. Additionally, higher income also reduces debt-to-income ratio, leaving the borrower with more disposable income to take on additional credit responsibly.

With low risk involved, borrowers can easily attract lower interest rates. Apart from these factors, another way to reduce your interest rate and processing fee is to negotiate with a lender when you have a high credit score, high income and fulfill all eligibility requirements.

In case your credit score is low, you can add a co-applicant with a stronger credit profile and stable income to increase the lender's confidence in your combined repayment capacity, which may help improve your eligibility, especially for high-ticket loans.

(The writer is CEO of Paisabazaar)



ILLUSTRATION-SAAI

NSEIX opens doors to U.S. stocks for Indian investors

From Apple to Alphabet, some of the world's biggest technology giants could soon find their way into Indian portfolios through NSEIX's Global Access platform

UNCLE SAM CALLING

Vaishali R. Venkat

For decades, buying U.S. stocks has been a Herculean task for most Indian investors. Strict remittance rules, a maze of paperwork, an arduous hunt for reliable and cost-effective overseas brokers, steep account-opening charges and the list of challenges goes on. On top of that, there are lingering concerns over overseas shareholdings' safety.

With technological advances, financial innovations and regulatory reforms, buying U.S. firms' shares from India may soon be an app/website away.

Thanks to the NSE International Exchange Global Access (NSEIX-GA). With NSEIX-GA, the line between Dalal Street and Wall Street blurs, bringing some of Silicon Valley's most valuable firms within Indian portfolios' reach.

Fully regulated
The NSEIX Global Access IFSC Ltd. is a subsidiary of NSE International Exchange (NSEIX), which in turn is owned by the National Stock Exchange (NSE) of India. It's a fully regulated entity operating from Gujarat International Finance Tec-City (GIFT City), Gandhinagar, under the regulatory framework of the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA). It enables investors to access global

Any Indian resident over age 18 can open an account with the NSEIX GA for free, through official website nseixga.com and get digitally onboarded

securities via IFSC ecosystem.

No paperwork
You can now directly buy stocks listed on the New York Stock Exchange (NYSE) and Nasdaq via NSEIX-GA which acts as a super broker.

Any Indian resident above 18 years of age can open an account with the NSEIX-GA for free, through official website nseixga.com and experience fully-digital onboarding. PAN/Aadhaar card details could be automatically fetched via Digilocker with the KYC process done digitally.

No demat account
There is no need to open a separate demat account. Once an account is opened with the NSEIX-GA, individuals can start investing via the app or website. Investors can download NSEIX global access' mobile app with both Android and iOS versions available. Financial experts say the NSEIX Global Access' initiative would democratise how Indians gain access to international bourses. The NSEIX-GA, being a government-promoted institution, ensures the security

The entire technology platform/ process is designed in a manner that trades would be executed and settled in real time based on nations' market timings

of overseas holdings.

More foreign markets
Currently, the NSEIX-GA is ready with the offerings of U.S. stocks, especially NYSE and NASDAQ with plans afoot to connect with several other big global bourses. It is likely that almost 30 big foreign markets would be included soon. Plans are on to include Europe, the U.K., Japan, Korea and Australian markets too. With this, investors would have huge choice to diversify holdings.

An official said, "For a hassle-free back-end process, we have tied up with many countries as well as foreign brokers. The entire technology platform and the process is designed in a manner that trades would be executed and settled in real time based on the market timings of the respective countries."

For instance, the U.S. equity trades ideally follow T+1 settlement viz. trades would be settled one business day after execution. Therefore, funds or U.S. Securities become fully settled only after this settlement cycle completes."

Investors can remit mo-

ney from their bank accounts to the NSEIX-GA account in Gandhinagar Gift city and once the funds get reflected in the account, investors get trading limits power to buy shares.

Fractional investing
NSEIX-GA allows fractional investing viz. Indian investors can buy a portion/fraction of a U.S.-listed share rather than purchasing the entire stock. This can be particularly useful since many leading U.S. stocks trade at high prices.

Tax, RBI scheme
Capital gains on U.S. equities are not taxed in the U.S under the India-U.S. tax treaty. They are taxable only in India. Dividends attract a 25% U.S. withholding tax which can be later claimed as a foreign tax credit in India. Also, overseas investments are made under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS) which permits individuals to remit up to \$2.50 lakh/financial year. No Tax Collected at Source (TCS) applies on foreign remittances up to ₹10 lakh in a financial year while amounts above this attract TCS. Investors must also report overseas investments and income in Indian tax returns. Investors must, however, approach global markets with careful research, awareness of risks and understanding of cross-border regulations.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)

Choices drive your decision

THINKINVESTOR

The choice between lump-sum investment and RCA leads to different behaviour; for most, diversification is investing in multiple funds with an intent to moderate future regret

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Do you 'diversify' when making lumpy investments and face many choices? Or "diversify" as you have underlying strategy to cut downside risk? Here, we discuss diversification heuristics which behavioural psychologists describe as how we behave when faced with many choices with large investment capital.

Choice matters

Suppose you decide to invest ₹5 lakh in equity funds. It is highly unlikely you will invest the entire sum in a single active fund. You may want to spread the money across, say, five funds. But the funds could have overlapping stocks. Why? Most people invest in large-cap, mid-cap, flexi-cap and thematic funds. There may be an overlap in stock holdings between large-cap and mid-cap funds as large-cap and mid-cap funds can hold up to 20% and 35% in mid-cap and large-cap stocks. There could be huge overlaps in holdings between flexi-cap style and thematic funds. This is because thematic, strategy and style indices are carved out of broad-cap index, the benchmark for flexi-cap funds. Ignoring the overlap, you may have significantly reduced anxiety by investing across these funds.

What if you equally spread the investment over 10 months through a systematic investment plan (SIP)? This is referred to as rupee-cost averaging (RCA). It is highly unlikely you will spread ₹50,000/month SIP across five funds. At the extreme, you may even invest in only one fund. Why?

It is typical behaviour to choose multiple funds when you invest lump-sum money and have several investment choices. This is referred to as diversification heuristics. This is our brain's way of moderating future regret. What if you invest the entire money in one fund and the funds you considered but did not choose those performing better? "Diversifying" across funds reduces this anxiety. We are arguably unlikely to suffer from diversification heuristics with RCA as the investments are spread across time and therefore, the investment performance is not so obvious.

Conclusion

The choice between lump-sum investment and RCA leads to different behaviour. We choose multiple funds when faced with simultaneous choices (lumpy investments) but not necessarily with sequential choices (RCA). The above was meant to bring to the fore a point on diversification – for most individuals, diversification is about investing in multiple funds with an intent to moderate future regret.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Small Finance Banks				
AU Small Finance Bank	7.10	6.35	7.10	6.75
Equitas Small Finance Bank	7.40	6.90	7.00	7.00
ESAF Small Finance Bank	8.00	4.75	6.00	5.75
Jana Small Finance Bank	8.25	7.00	7.50	7.77
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	7.80	6.00	6.75	6.25
slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	7.90	7.25	7.25	7.90
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.45	7.25	7.20	7.20
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	7.50	6.00	7.50	7.00
Private Sector Banks				
Axis Bank	6.45	6.25	6.45	6.45
Bandhan Bank	7.25	7.00	7.00	5.85
City Union Bank	7.00	6.80	6.50	6.25
CSB Bank	7.00	5.00	5.75	5.75
DBS Bank	6.60	6.30	6.40	6.25
DCB Bank	7.15	6.90	7.00	7.15
Federal Bank	6.75	6.25	6.75	6.40
HDFC Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.40
ICICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.50	6.30	7.00	7.00
Indusind Bank	7.00	6.75	6.90	6.65

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Public Sector Banks				
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	7.25	6.75	6.65	6.60
IDBI Bank	6.50	6.20	6.35	6.25
Karnataka Bank	6.65	6.50	6.15	6.15
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.70	6.50	6.40	6.25
RBL Bank	7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70
SBM Bank India	7.85	7.10	7.10	7.00
South Indian Bank	6.70	6.35	6.20	5.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.10	6.80	6.60	6.60
YES Bank	7.00	6.65	7.00	6.75
Public Sector Banks				
Bank of Baroda	6.45	6.10	6.25	6.30
Bank of India	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.00
Bank of Maharashtra	6.65	6.20	5.25	5.00
Canara Bank	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
Central Bank of India	6.50	6.20	6.00	6.00
Indian Bank	6.60	6.10	6.05	6.00
Indian Overseas Bank	6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10
Punjab National Bank	6.60	6.25	6.30	6.10
Punjab & Sind Bank	6.75	5.85	5.85	5.95
State Bank of India	6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05
Union Bank of India	6.60	6.30	6.25	6.00

Home Loan Interest Rates

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Public Sector Banks			
State Bank of India	7.25-8.70	7.25-8.70	7.25-8.70
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Union Bank of India*	7.15-9.50	7.15-9.50	7.15-9.50
Punjab National Bank	7.25-9.10	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
Bank of Maharashtra	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70
Indian Overseas Bank	7.10 #	7.10 #	7.10 #
Indian Bank	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55
Central Bank of India	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15
Private Sector Banks			
Kotak Mahindra Bank	7.70 #	7.70 #	7.70 #
ICICI Bank	7.65 #	7.65 #	7.65 #
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00 - 9.10
HSBC Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
South Indian Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Karur Vysya Bank	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65
Karnataka Bank	7.30-11.68	7.30-11.68	7.30-11.68

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
Federal Bank	8.30 - 10.75	7.30 - 10.75	7.30 - 9.75
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30
Bandhan Bank	8.41-12.58	8.41-12.58	8.41-12.58
RBL Bank	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
CSB Bank	8.05 #	8.05 #	8.05 #
HDFC Bank	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
City Union Bank	8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
LIC Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Bajaj Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Tata Capital	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
PNB Housing Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
GIC Housing Finance	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
SMFG India Home Finance	10.00 #	10.00 #	10.00 #
Aditya Birla Capital	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
ICICI Home Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Godrej Housing Finance	7.60 #	7.60 #	7.60 #
*Extra interest rate concession of 0.05% to borrowers opting for insurance policy Rates as on March 18 #onwards Source:Paisabazaar.com			

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.

Seven killed in Qatar helicopter crash due to technical malfunction



Patriot missile involved in Bahrain blast likely U.S.-operated: report



Saudi Arabia orders expulsion of Iran military attache, embassy staff

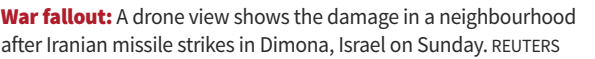


Britain sees no evidence that Iran is targeting Europe with missiles

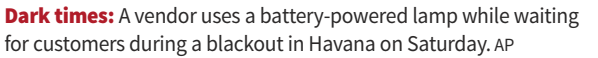


At least 47 people were injured after an Iranian missile struck the Israeli town of Dimona, home to a large Indian Jewish population and located close to a secretive nuclear reactor; IDF says it is probing incident after air defences fail to intercept

TEL AVIV/JERUSALEM



Indian shops are spread across the town, and Ma-



CAIRO

BOGOTÁ

[illegible]

Sport

A LOT TO DO

Pant is under pressure to deliver in IPL 2026, feels du Plessis



FILE PHOTO: SANDEEP SAXENA

Rishabh Pant is probably one player who is under immense pressure in IPL 2026. Some guys flourish under the pressure of the price tag, while some don't. Last season was really tough for him. The team struggled, and he also struggled with the bat. This IPL will be crucial for him — Faf du Plessis about the LSG skipper.

BASELESS

Kohli laughs off chartered flights to London reports ahead of IPL 2026



K. MURALI KUMAR

Royal Challengers Bengaluru batter Virat Kohli rubbished the reports of him requesting the RCB management for access to chartered flights between India and London during IPL 2026. Talking to Instagram, Virat posted one of these reports on his story along with laughing emojis, indicating that these reports are false.

IN & OUT

Shanaka set to replace injured Curran at Rajasthan Royals



AFF

Sri Lanka all-rounder Dasun Shanaka is set to replace the injured Sam Curran at Rajasthan Royals for IPL 2026. Shanaka is said to have informed PSL franchise Lahore Qalandars about the move. Curran, who was part of a pre-auction trade between CSK and RR, has a groin issue, which ruled him out of the IPL.

TOUGH CALL

Humpy withdraws from the FIDE Candidates tournament



FILE PHOTO: G.N. RAO

After deep reflection, I have taken the difficult decision to withdraw from the FIDE Women's Candidates tournament. Despite the assurances provided, I do not feel fully secure under the current circumstances. This is a painful but necessary decision, and I stand by it — Indian GM Koneru Humpy.

Batting-heavy Sunrisers hope to bowl rivals over

The Hyderabad franchise boasts some of the world's best T20 batters; in the absence of regular skipper Cummins, medium-pacers Harshal and Unadkat must do the heavy lifting among bowlers

Anirudh Velamuri

Sunrisers Hyderabad enters IPL 2026 with a familiar identity and one built on enviable batting firepower. On paper, it once again boasts the league's most formidable batting line-up that is capable of outscoring any opponent. Yet, some questions linger. Will this batting might be enough to carry it all the way? Can a largely inexperienced bowling unit, sans Pat Cummins for the opening matches, hold its own against IPL's big hitters? Focusing on its forte makes sense, but is it wise to be over-dependent on it?

Explosive line-up

To be fair to the team, Sunrisers' approach is not without logic. When your core features Abhishek Sharma and Ishan Kishan, two of the world's best T20 batters, you are naturally inclined to double down on that.

Add to it the explosiveness of Travis Head, Heinrich Klaasen and Nitish Kumar, the blueprint becomes clear — overwhelm, outscore and outlast the rivals.

IPL-19 COUNTDOWN

Sunrisers Hyderabad

OVERALL NUMBERS				
M	W	L	NR	
196	94	101	1	
BY OPPONENT				
	M	W	L	NR
CSK	22	7	15	0
DC	26	13	12	1
GT	6	1	5	0
KKR	30	10	20	0
LSG	6	2	4	0
MI	25	10	15	0
PBKS	24	17	7	0
RCB	25	14	11	0
RR	21	12	9	0

SRH'S 2026 LEAGUE CAMPAIGN*			
March 28	vs. RCB	Bengaluru	7.30 p.m.
April 2	vs. KKR	Kolkata	7.30 p.m.
April 5	vs. LSG	Hyderabad	3.30 p.m.
April 11	vs. PBKS	New Chandigarh	3.30 p.m.

*announced so far

Sunrisers' remaining matches were against GL (5), RPS (4) and PWI (2)



ISHAN KISHAN

MIRACLE MAN

Taking the spotlight off 'Travishek' is no small task, yet Ishan Kishan enters IPL 2026 as Sunrisers' in-form batter. He rebuilt his game through domestic dominance and carried that momentum into the international arena. SRH's faith in his prowess is evident, with Kishan named stand-in captain while Pat Cummins works back to full fitness. Kishan leads by example as his Jharkhand teammates would attest. The 27-year-old could set the tone for a memorable campaign.

THE SQUAD

Ishan Kishan (Capt.), Abhishek Sharma (Vice-capt.), Pat Cummins, Travis Head, Aniket Verma, R. Smaran, Ishan Kishan, Heinrich Klaasen, Nitish Kumar, Harsh Dubey, Kamindu Mendis, Harshal Patel, Brydon Carse, Jaydev Unadkat, Eshan Malinga, Zeeshan Ansari, Salil Arora, Shivang Kumar, Sakib Hussain, Onkar Tarmale, Krains Fuletra, Praful Hinge, Amit Kumar, Shivam Mavi, and Liam Livingstone.

*Cummins has been ruled out of the first few matches



Locked in: Kishan in a conversation with head coach Vettori. SUNRISERS HYDERABAD

T. Natarajan) in the attack. Now, Harshal Patel and Jaydev Unadkat will have to shoulder that responsibility.

At the auction, the Hyderabad outfit, despite having the third-largest purse, turned to a mix of domestic seamers and promising prospects. Among the lesser-known names, young left-arm spinners Krains

Fuletra and Shivang Kumar stand out. Whether they are entrusted with meaningful tasks remains to be seen.

The home conditions, at least, offer some comfort. The Rajiv Gandhi International Stadium has traditionally produced flat, batting-friendly pitches, which the Hyderabad team used effectively in 2024 to

win five of its seven home games en route a runner-up finish. Ultimately, Sunrisers' season may hinge on a simple yet decisive balance. Its batting will win it games, perhaps many. If the bowling unit can rise from a point of vulnerability to one of reliability, this could be a complete side. If not, it risks a familiar story: spectacular but short.

COMPILED BY G. PRASAD & ANIRUDH VELAMURI

Anahat and Abhay make it a double delight at Indian Open

SQUASH

Sports Bureau
MUMBAI

It turned out to be a night of celebration for Indian squash fans as Abhay Singh and Anahat Singh won the men's and women's titles at the JSW Indian Open squash tournament on Sunday.

The men's title decider, an all-Indian battle, saw second-seeded Abhay overpower fourth seed Veer Chotrani 11-9, 11-8, 11-4 while Anahat cruised past Egypt's Hana Moataz 11-5, 11-6, 9-11, 11-6 in the women's final.

Abhay was in superb form on the big day. Although Veer put up a fight in the first two games, the second seed switched gears as the match progressed.

"Indian squash is very healthy right now with four men in the top 50 and Anahat is leading the charts in the Women's World Champs. Obviously, the goal individually is the Los Angeles Olympics, but we all have a big year ahead with the Asian Games," said Abhay.

Sublime show

Earlier, Anahat Singh produced a sublime show, coming up with a lethal combination of deception and speedy cross-court movement to leave her opponent in a daze.



Ruling the roost: Anahat and Abhay were hardly stretched in the title deciders. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

"I think it's really amazing how Hana played. She was not well the past week, reached the finals after a tough full-hour match on Saturday. She still came out and put on such a great

performance. It was amazing to watch. I'm glad we were able to put on a good fight for the audience and, hopefully, everyone had fun watching," said Anahat.

Araujo, 'keeper Garcia dazzle in Barca's win

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
BARCELONA

Ronald Araujo's header proved to be the difference as LaLiga leader Barcelona bagged a tight 1-0 win over Rayo Vallecano on Sunday.

Araujo nodded home Joao Cancelo's corner in the 24th minute to help the host earn the three points at Camp Nou, while goalkeeper Joan Garcia's superb display played just as big a part in the victory.

In Serie A, Como took control of the league's final Champions League spot by thrashing relegation-threatened Pisa 5-0 on Sunday. It was Como's fifth straight victory in Serie A.

In the Premier League on Saturday, Chelsea's hopes of Champions League qualification suffered another blow as Everton stormed to a 3-0 home win.

Beto struck twice before Iliman Ndiaye rounded off Everton's best win at its new home so far. Chelsea has now lost four consecutive games to put manager Liam Rosenior under pressure.

The results: LaLiga: Barcelona 1 (Araujo 24) bt Rayo Vallecano 0. **Premier League:** Newcastle 1 (Gordon 10) lost to Sunderland 2 (Talbi 57, Brobbey 90); Aston Villa 2 (McGinn 15, Watkins 68) bt West Ham 0; Tottenham 0 lost to Nottingham Forest 3 (Jesus 45, Gibbs-White 62, Awoniyi 87).

Serie A: Como 5 (Diao 7, Douvakis 29, Baturina 48, Paz 75, Perrone 81) bt Pisa 0

On Saturday: LaLiga: Espanyol 1 (Fernandez 68) lost to Getafe 2 (Duarte 45+3, Aramburri 45+7). **Premier League:** Everton 3 (Beto 33, 62, Ndiaye 76) bt Chelsea 0.

Serie A: Juventus 1 (Yidiz 14) drew with Sassuolo 1 (Pinamonti 52); AC Milan 3 (Pavlovic 37, Rabiot 54, Fofana 56) bt Torino 2 (Simeone 44, Vlasic 83-pen).

Bundesliga: Borussia Dortmund 3 (Bensebaini 73-pen, 84-pen, Guirassy 78) bt Hamburg 2 (Otele 19, Lokonga 38).



Top stuff: Araujo unlocks Rayo's defence with his headed goal. AFP



Taking his chance: Irfan punished Goa for committing a defensive blunder. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Jhingan's late leveller denies CFC a winning start at home

ISL

K. Keerthivasan
CHENNAI

FC Goa pulled off a 1-1 draw after scoring at the death in the Indian Super League thriller against Chennaiyin FC at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium here on Sunday.

Just when Chennaiyin looked set for its first home win of the season, Sandesh Jhingan capped off the visitor's late surge with the equaliser in the 88th minute. The India international rose highest to deliver a thunderous header off Dejan Drazic's corner-kick.

Chennaiyin had seized the advantage through Irfan Yadwad as the substi-

tute had punished Goa for committing a defensive blunder in the 48th minute. A casual back-pass from Sahil Tavora was pounced upon by Irfan, who intercepted it, surged forward and beat Goa goalkeeper Hritvik Tiwari.

The Clifford Miranda-coached side, which now has five points from as many matches, appeared in control for long spells of the contest but struggled to withstand Goa's late onslaught. Goa moved to 10 points from six games after dominating the closing quarter with crisp passing and sustained pressure in the box. The visiting side nearly completed the turnaround in stoppage time. Boris Singh forced a sharp

save from 'keeper Mohammad Nawaz, before Daniel Lalhlimpuia fired narrowly over the crossbar moments later.

Earlier, the first half — though goalless — was far from dull, with both sides creating lively openings. Chennaiyin suffered a blow when striker Daniel Chima Chukwu was stretched off following an injury. In the end, Jhingan landed another punch to deny Chennaiyin a winning start at home.

The results: Chennaiyin FC 1 (Irfan Yadwad 48) drew with FC Goa 1 (Sandesh Jhingan 88).

At Kolkata: Inter Kashi FC 1 (Alfred Planas 38) lost to Bengaluru FC 3 (Ashique Kuruniyan 20, Braian Sanchez 69, 90+8).

EDUCATIONPLUS

GET THE EDGE Follow us facebook.com/thehindu twitter.com/the_hindu instagram.com/the_hindu

H. Kalpana Rao

Earlier this year, I sent a New Year's card to a student who was visually impaired and was taken aback when he responded saying that he had used an AI tool that provided him with details of the layout, the colours, the pictures within the frame, and even the emotional framework of the image. The confidence with which he immediately pointed out that he was able to grasp the image's nuances through an AI-generated tool made a deep impression on me.

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is today being viewed as an advantage and a disadvantage in relation to academic integrity, learning ability, and evaluation. But the above incident compelled me to rethink the capacities of AI and the range of its possible uses within the field of disability.

Persistent difficulty

For years, instructors have devised innumerable ways to teach, educate, and communicate with students with diverse disabilities. Yet, one of the persistent difficulties has been enabling such students to participate fully in the classroom. For instance, a visually impaired student who had to dictate to a scribe invariably took longer than others to complete a writing task. Added to this was the scribe's own ability to write the dictated material correctly.

With AI, such students can dictate and use generative tools to produce res-



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

AI for inclusive education

While AI tools can help create an inclusive environment for students with disabilities, educators also should be aware of the problems involved

ponses. Of course, there is potential for misuse but, with appropriate monitoring, this challenge can be addressed.

Similarly, AI can be used to understand maps and charts and assist with reading quickly. Teachers can also create assignments that match the students' intellectual abilities, thereby instilling appropriate challenges. AI can also assist other kinds of disabilities, such as students with cerebral palsy, allowing them to transcribe their thoughts and write meaningfully.

While teaching postgraduate students, I often faced challenges when working with visually impaired learners. Although I often read passages aloud and encouraged discussions so that all students could follow what was happening, there were moments when I would sometimes write key terms and references on the blackboard, forgetting that visually impaired students could not access what was written. Over the years, I became more aware of their needs and would consciously speak louder so

that they could record the audio. I also searched for e-books so that they could access the material independently.

But, in many Indian universities, teachers are not fully aware of how to create equitable and inclusive environments not because they lack the desire but because classrooms are often ill-equipped and have minimal technological access. Additionally, the heavy load of teaching and administrative work makes teaching feel like a burden rather than a pleasure.

It is high time that educators in India become aware of the various tools and strategies emerging through AI to support students. More importantly, curricula and syllabi need to be co-designed with disabled students and instructors so that lived experiences can shape more effective learning. The need of the hour is for university administrators to ensure that faculty are trained to meet the needs of disabled students. Training in the use of and understanding how AI can help innovate and support in-

clusive teaching practices is essential. Policymakers should also set guardrails to ensure that technologies remain unbiased and inclusive of diverse perspectives.

Cause of concern

While the use of AI is exciting, it is also a cause of concern. Many AI tools collect user data and store it and this could lead to unwanted data exposure. Moreover, there could be the potential for the data to be collected in methods that are not very transparent. As a result, it could create a risk between technological enhancement and surveillance, especially when data protection protocols are not well-crafted.

Yet another issue that needs to be tackled is that AI systems could be stereotypical, as they are generated using vast data sets and in cultures that may be different. As a result, it may misread the needs of individual students and create problems in assessment and evaluation. A third issue is that students could become too dependent on it and may not understand that it is only a tool to enable them to earn better. Yet, if teachers understand the principles of ethics, integrity, and moral responsibility, AI can become a powerful tool to enhance learning and knowledge among students with disabilities.

The writer is a former professor of English at Pondicherry University and now volunteers as the editor for the literary section of the online journal, *Muse India*. Email: hkalp.eng@ponduni.ac.in

SCHOLARSHIPS

University of Bath School of Management Scholarships

Offered by the School of Management, University of Bath, the U.K.

Eligibility: Students who have accepted an offer for one of the eligible taught postgraduate Master's courses in 2026-27 and have applied for a scholarship within the deadline.

Rewards: Up to €10,000 fee waiver.

Application: Online

Deadline: April 8

www.b4s.in/edge/UBMS2

Masters' Union Scholarship

Offered by Masters' Union

Eligibility: Students who have passed Class 12 and want to do a full-time UG programme in Business Management; Technology;

Leadership; Design; Sustainability; Finance and Economics; Marketing, or related fields and score in Masters' Union Scholarship Aptitude Test (MUSAT) or approved alternate test.

Rewards: Fee waivers ranging from 10-80%

Application: Online

Deadline: May 13

www.b4s.in/edge/MUSCASPI

ServiceScape Scholarship

Offered by ServiceScape.

Eligibility: Students above 18 years and enrolled or accepted in an accredited college, university, or trade school who submit an essay of 300-600 words on a topic provided by ServiceScape.

Rewards: \$1,000

Application: Online

Deadline: November 30

www.b4s.in/edge/SSSZ2

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Women in STEM

Progress Software has opened applications for the 2026 Progress Akanksha Scholarship for Women in STEM in India. This is a renewable four-year scholarship of up to ₹150,000 annually to support education-related expenses. Two recipients will be chosen based on academic achievement, financial need, interest and experience in

Computer Science, Software Engineering, IT and/or Computer Information Systems and other criteria.

Eligibility: Indian citizens who are women and enrolled in the first year of a Computer Science, Computer Science Information Technology or related courses with an aggregate of 75% or more in Class 12 and a family income not exceeding ₹500,000

Deadline: April 13

For details visit <https://tinyurl.com/sr764hne>



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

I am doing B.Sc. Biotechnology, but my goal is the Civil Services. I chose this without realising my true interests. I want to study Sociology, English, and Ethics at the PG level. How can I align this with my plans? Ayush

Dear Ayush,

Civil Services does not require a specific undergraduate degree, nor does it require continuity between UG and PG subjects.

Your interests in Sociology, English, and Ethics are highly aligned with UPSC.

Biotechnology will be very useful for General Studies to answer questions in science and technology. So it is also a helpful foundation.

Your Postgraduate choices could be M.A. Sociology (GS-I (Society) and GS-IV (Ethics) and the Essay paper. M.A. English will help in writing and articulation, the Essay paper and the possibility of choosing English as the optional paper.

A PG Diploma in Ethics or Public Policy will help with Ethics Case Studies, governance issues and also help in the interview stage.

I finished Class 10 in 2020 and chose PCMB, aiming to join the Indian Air Force. After Class 12, I missed the NDA's age eligibility. Due to CUET's introduction, I could not secure college admission, leading to a gap year. I enrolled in an online BCA programme. In 2024, I got admission to the B.Sc. Maths (Hons) and, due to financial issues, dropped the BCA. I am also preparing for the CDS and

Approach is key

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

AFCAT. If joining the defence forces doesn't work, I plan to build a stable career as a data analyst. I have completed a data analytics bootcamp, developed skills such as Excel, SQL, Python, Tableau, Power BI, and cloud tools. What should my next steps be? Nitin

Dear Nitin,

Your path looks a little 'zig-zag' on paper but it showcases your resilience, adaptability, and clarity of intent. You already know CDS/AFCAT are the direct routes but keep a time-bound plan and don't put your life on hold for this.

Create blocks of two to three hours dedicated to preparing for each task. Keep your Plan B also alive and active since you already have great momentum.

Your Maths (Hons.) background, analytics tools stack, and bootcamp exposure give you a good foundation for a data analyst role. Now, you need to focus on projects, internships or live work and visibility.

Work on building four to five solid end-to-end problem-based projects and host them on GitHub, Medium/Notion. Get some analytics experience via internships, contract roles, or projects in NGOs, research organisations or start-ups.

Leverage your Maths (Hons) knowledge and learn statistics for data analysis, hypothesis testing, probability concepts, and basic econometrics.

Work on your resume and profile. Network and connect with analysts on LinkedIn.

I finished B.Com in 2025. I am from a Hindi-medium background and aim to study in a top B-school. I

attempted the CAT a year ago, but did not score well. I am working on improving my quantitative and logical reasoning skills. How do I improve my English? Rajnandan

Dear Rajnandan,

Being from a Hindi-medium background is not a disadvantage. Poor English is a skill gap, not an identity problem. You can fix it!

Work on speaking with clarity, confidence, expressing ideas logically, and comprehending what is being said.

Read comprehension passages and work on CAT-relevant grammar. Your vocabulary doesn't need to be fancy but you should be able to express what you think and feel.

Practise mock interviews in English where you answer structured views, opinions, and check your confidence in delivery.

Read the English newspaper every day out loud, underline the ideas, summarise them in English and get someone to check it.

Practise speaking for around 15 minutes daily and record yourself. Start with simple everyday topics like "Why MBA", "My favourite food" or "My Best Holiday". Focus on your thoughts and expression. Start to think in English and try not to translate from Hindi to English.

Also work on improving writing skills and write short essays on any topic twice a week. Use positive affirmations and be proud of your roots and where you come from.

I am a Class 11 Humanities student preparing for CLAT 2027. I am unsure

about the opportunities and scope in Humanities. What are my options? Satyam

Dear Satyam,

Humanities builds critical thinking, reading and writing ability, and an understanding of society, law, politics, ethics ... all highly valuable skills in law, policy, media, education, research and governance.

Law is one of the strongest professional outcomes for Humanities students. After your law degree, you can get into litigation, corporate law, judiciary, policy and legislative roles, in-house counsel in companies, legal research, and think tanks.

The other options are undergraduate degrees in Political Science, History, Sociology, Psychology, English, Economics (if you have Maths) or Integrated B.A./M.A. or Integrated B.A./B.Ed. courses.

These can lead to multiple postgraduate and career options across public policy and governance, think tanks, research organisations, NGOs, print and digital content writing, corporate communication, civil services and other government exams, academia and so on.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

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I will go forward through runs and runs only

Smaran had a stupendous sophomore season as he accumulated a tournament-high 950 runs in the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy. After a sedate start to his domestic career in 2024, the 22-year-old from Karnataka has emerged as one of the brightest prospects in the country across formats

INTERVIEW

R. Smaran

N. Sudarshan

There is a studious zeal to how R. Smaran goes about his cricket. While batting, he is focused and efficient and not outrightly flashy and extravagant. While speaking, he is both poised and confident without sounding overtly cerebral and nerdy. These facets found wholesome expression in the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy as Smaran, 22, scored a chart-topping 950 runs in Karnataka's first run to the final in over a decade.

What made it all the more remarkable was the fact that the performance came when the side had accomplished batters Karun Nair and Devdutt Padikkal for a majority of the games, and K.L. Rahul for the last four.

The campaign may have ended in an anti-climax – he was out first ball to the sensational Jammu & Kashmir pacer Auqib Nabi in the final and Karnataka lost out on adding to its eight Ranji crowns - but the last time anyone younger than Smaran finished as the highest run-getter in India's premier red-ball tournament was when a 21-year-old Shreyas Iyer made 1321 runs in 2015-16.

Smaran, under whose captaincy Karnataka won its maiden C.K. Nayudu (U-23) Trophy in 2023-24, spoke to *The Hindu* on his superlative season, his batting methods and mindset, and the upcoming IPL with Sunrisers Hyderabad. Excerpts:

How does it feel to be the highest run-getter in the Ranji Trophy?

It's a great feeling. I set out at the beginning of the season with certain goals - score 1000 runs or remain at the top of the run charts. I fell short by 50 runs, but to be top is great. I am really grateful to god for giving me the platform and that many games to get those many runs.

You debuted in 2024-25. How different was season two from season one?

This time we went till the final in Ranji Trophy and I got to play that many more games in different conditions. There were a lot of learnings as to how I can tackle spin better, play fast bowlers better on a green top. We had a lot of experienced guys who play for the country joining us from the knockouts. We missed out on winning, but I learnt a lot both by being there in the middle and in the dressing room.

How did you sustain your red-ball form, across nine matches and nearly five months? Ranji is now played in two parts and the white-ball competitions are sandwiched...

The preparation in the off-season is done in the same way. You quickly switch between formats and practice in such a way that you don't have much time to adjust. When you move from white ball to red, most batters tend to go for their shots and continue the same momentum. But red ball requires patience. You can still play your shots, but you need to know what your game is and how there's a pattern to scoring runs.

Do you have a favourite knock?

The Mumbai one (83 n.o. in the fourth innings) would be my favourite. It was against Mumbai in Mumbai and when the situation was against us. We were three down [for 119], and chasing 325 is never easy. There was a small amount of nerves going in because in the three innings before that I hadn't got runs. It was a do-or-die situation, but after I got a couple of boundaries in the first four-five balls, I eased a bit.

Rahul at the other end guided me as to what shots I could play and which bowlers to take on. We quickly put on 70-80 runs, and the field started spreading out. That knock is right up there.

What were you most pleased about?

The way I handled pressure after



NIRMAL HARINDRAN

Rahul got out. Shreyas Gopal and Kruthik Krishna were also out quickly [with 40 runs needed], but the way I handled the pressure to take the game deep, rotate the strike and not go for the big shots... that is something I rate highly.

How have you progressed as a batter, from age-group cricket to the senior side?

Not many major changes technique-wise, but just about putting more value on your wicket. In the longest format, it is easy to throw away your wicket when you are settled.

It is important to know your gameplan, bat the opposition out of the game and give your bowlers the time to get 20 wickets.

I have had a lot of conversations with our coach Yere [Goud] sir, and with Karun and a lot of senior players about this.

Three of your six First Class centuries are double hundreds, and the three others are 135, 134 and 127. What's with you and big knocks?

It's just the hunger to convert hundreds into big hundreds. In India, you have so many talented players and almost every other guy gets a century.

The only way you can differentiate yourself from others is by scoring 160, 170 and double hundreds.

The emphasis is also on giving our bowlers enough time. If I get out immediately after my century, the new guy will find it hard.

In Karnataka's 2024-25 Vijay Hazare Trophy triumph, you made 433 runs including a century in the final. In two editions of Syed Mushtaq Ali T20, you have a strike-rate of around 160. What has worked for you across formats?

Preparation in the off-season. Like I said before, you bat two-three days of red ball and then switch to white ball. But even in the shorter formats, it's very important to know your game. For me, even if it's in T20s, it is essential to observe those initial four-five balls.



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nowadays, you don't have that luxury, and that is something I'm really working on. But for playing different formats, a lot of credit goes to my coach Syed [Zabiulla] sir and the regimen he put forward.

Being an all-format batter in India is tough. India's Test and ODI captain [Shubman Gill] is not even there in the T20 team. How much work goes into compartmentalising your approaches?

A lot. When you make the switch, sometimes you still are in the past format.

Personally, I feel, anything that you do out there in the middle is a result of repeated practice.

The more repetitions you do, it becomes easier. Playing all three formats is never going to be easy. Practice has to be put into all three equally to ensure you excel.

I wanted to wind back a bit. Before you made your Karnataka debut in October 2024, your age-group teammates such as K.V. Aneesh, or the very young Hardik Raj, had already made the grade. Was there a feeling that your progress was slow? How confident were you that you will eventually get there, especially having once missed out on a U-19 India slot?

During that U-19 phase, I thought it was all about playing U-19 India. I didn't even think about Ranji because U-19 India had so much value. But immediately after that, I kept no expectations.

When I played C.K. Nayudu Trophy, I felt that good things will always come to good people. I just needed to keep my head down and keep scoring.

Even when guys around me were going ahead and playing Ranji Trophy, I felt that they were going there because they had scored a lot of runs and taken a lot of wickets.

I believed my due will come. Even now, the only way I'll go forward is through runs and runs only.

The C.K. Nayudu championship win

really helped personally and I got my due.

Your first five Ranji Trophy matches were unremarkable, with a highest of 37. Can you talk about that period?

It's a very proud feeling to represent your State and a lot of expectations come with it. Like any other player, I felt that I needed to cement my place. But I forgot to enjoy the game and the process of getting those big runs. In those five matches, I was not in the right headspace. But after that, we went into the Syed Mushtaq Ali and Vijay Hazare trophies and I spoke to a lot of people. They told me to enjoy the game and not worry about the outcome.

I started doing that, and one thing led to the other. In the span of one-and-a-half months, we had the Vijay Hazare Trophy in our hands. It helped me build momentum for the second half of Ranji, and I got the double hundred against Punjab (203).

The IPL is next, and what are your expectations? You came in as a replacement player for Sunrisers in 2025 but didn't play because you got injured. But the franchise retained you, and you will now be with some of the best T20 players like Abhishek Sharma, Travis Head, Heinrich Klaasen...

I am very grateful to Sunrisers for having put their faith in me even though I was ruled out of the IPL last year.

They back a lot of youngsters, and I am looking forward to fulfilling whatever role is given to me.

The IPL is a long tournament and momentum is a big factor. With guys like Abhishek and Ishan [Kishan] coming in from the T20 World Cup win, it is going to help us.

To play with those who have dominated the T20 format over the past two, three years is a great thing.

It will help me assess my own game and improve. We reached the final two years back and we won in 2016. Hopefully, we can replicate 2016 in 2026.

